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S. Bhagwant Singh Mann
Chief Minister, Punjab

India explores new options: Canada, Australia offer additional gas supply

‘The Strait of Hormuz is not the only route for India’s crude imports & the days of dependence on a single maritime chokepoint are long over’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With India exploring alternative sources to further strengthen its energy security, countries like Australia, Canada and several others have offered additional gas supplies, official sources said on Saturday.

Citing the ongoing US-Israel conflict with Iran leading to the closure of the key shipping route through the Strait of Hormuz, sources said the passage is not the only route for India’s crude imports and asserted that the days of dependence on a single maritime chokepoint are long over.

They noted that supplies from Russia, West Africa, the Americas, Central Asia, and non-Gulf Middle Eastern routes have ensured that disruption in any single corridor results in a managed sourcing adjustment, rather than a supply emergency.

Only around 40 per cent of India’s crude imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, while about 60 per cent are routed through other supply routes that remain unaffected, they said. This has ensured that there has been no shortage of energy for Indian consumers even during global turmoil or the pandemic, sources said.



‘Supplies from Russia, West Africa, the Americas, Central Asia, & non-Gulf Middle Eastern routes have ensured that disruption in any single corridor results in a managed sourcing adjustment’

Several countries, including Australia and Canada, have also offered additional gas supplies, and India continues to explore alternative sources to further strengthen energy security, they said. India has also recently entered into new energy supply arrangements with partners such as the United States and the United Arab Emirates to ensure stable long-term supplies.

Over the last decade, India’s strategic oil diplomacy has expanded its supplier base

from 27 to 40 countries across six continents. The days when India’s energy security rose and fell with conditions in a single maritime chokepoint are over, sources said.

They highlighted that India’s energy procurement decisions are governed by one principle — national interest. “We source crude from wherever supplies are available, competitively priced, and deliverable, and we will continue to do so. This has been our consistent

Key Points

- » ‘Only around 40% of India’s crude imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, while about 60% are routed through other supply routes’
- » India has also entered into new energy supply pacts with partners such as the US and the UAE to ensure stable supplies
- » Over the last decade, India’s strategic oil diplomacy has expanded supplier base from 27 to 40 nations across six continents

position across administrations and across geopolitical cycles,” a senior government official said, adding that the recent US statements are meant for the country’s domestic audience.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Friday announced a 30-day waiver permitting Indian refiners to continue purchases of Russian oil, describing India as an essential partner.

India has complied with all 18 rounds of G7 price cap rules since they were introduced.

The waiver removes a friction that was never in anyone’s interest to sustain and recognises the stabilising role India’s refining and procurement capacity has played in global energy markets.

India remains in close touch with major global crude oil and gas suppliers as well as international energy institutions such as the International Energy Agency (IEA) & the OPEC, sources said.

“India acted within international law throughout. Every transaction used compliant shipping, audited channels, and legal traders. India did not break the rules. India stabilised markets and the record of global crude prices during a period when India was actively procuring is the clearest evidence of that,” the official added.

Sources said every decision taken by the government in the petroleum sector is guided by three criteria — affordability, availability, and sustainability.

On fuel prices, the sources noted that petrol prices rose by about 55 per cent in Pakistan, 22 per cent in Germany, 19 per cent in France, and 11.54 per cent in the US during the same period, while India’s petrol prices increased by less than 1 per cent.

AMID WEST ASIA CRISIS

Govt asks ports to consider waiving charges, issues SoPs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Union Shipping, Ports and Waterways Ministry has proposed that ports may consider requests regarding reduction, waiver or remission of charges, including change of vessel charge, and also rolled out a standard operating procedure (SoP) for them to deal with issues arising from the West Asia crisis.

As part of the SoP that followed extensive consultations with all stakeholders on Friday, each port will appoint a nodal officer at the level of head of department or deputy head of department, who will be the single point of contact for addressing the issues coming up for consideration at ports.

The nodal officer will be responsible for taking up the matter with the competent authority and ensure that the action is taken within 24-72 hours.

Also, as per the SoP, port chairpersons should have periodic meetings with stakeholders such as shipping lines, exporters, terminal operators, customs, among others to closely monitor the situation and ascertain and address legitimate concerns.

The ministry also said that the port may consider various facilitation measures such as considering requests from users regarding reduction, waiver or remission of storage rent and change of vessel charge, among



As part of the SoP each port will appoint a nodal officer at the level of head of department or deputy head of department, who will be the single point of contact for addressing the issues coming up for consideration at ports

others on a case-to-case basis, depending on the prevailing circumstances at the port.

It said the port may also consider permitting the storage of cargo destined for the Middle East as transshipment cargo during the affected period besides allotting additional storage area, if required, for storing such cargo during the crisis.

Ports may also consider facilitating berthing of ad-hoc call vessels for dropping or picking Middle East bound transhipment cargo and expeditiously facilitating ‘Back to Town’ movement of export cargo lying in port premises in

co-ordination with Customs, it said.

Besides, ports may provide priority handling for perishable cargo to prevent deterioration and give priority to export cargo returning from the Middle East, in addition to facilitating additional bunkering capacity, wherever feasible, to meet potential demand, the ministry said.

Ports have been directed to coordinate closely with agencies such as Customs, DGFT and other relevant authorities to ensure implementation of these measures within the stipulated timelines, it stated.

‘Govt to restore full RoDTEP benefits to exporters from April 1’

NEW DELHI: The Commerce Ministry has assured exporters that full benefits under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) scheme will be restored from April 1, offering relief amid challenges arising from the West Asia crisis, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) said on Saturday.

The government had on February 23 halved RoDTEP rates for most sectors, except agriculture and processed food products. FIEO President S C Ralhan said the reduced 50 per cent RoDTEP rates will remain applicable only till March 31, 2026.

The assurance was given by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) during a meeting with FIEO.

Launched in 2021, the RoDTEP scheme refunds taxes, duties and levies incurred during manufacturing and distribution that are not reimbursed through other central, state or local mechanisms. Refund rates range from 0.3-3.9 per cent.

Exporters are also facing rising freight and insurance costs due to the West Asia conflict, which could affect price competitiveness in global markets.

In price-sensitive sectors, even a 1-2 per cent rise in costs can influence export orders. AGENCIES

Govt provides certain relaxations to exporters to meet obligations

NEW DELHI: The government has granted certain relaxations to exporters in fulfilling their export obligations, as the trading community is facing difficulties in the movement of goods due to the ongoing West Asia crisis, according to a notification.

“In view of the prevailing geo-political developments affecting international shipping routes and global supply chains, and with a view to facilitating exporters, the export obligation (EO) period/block wise EO period in respect of specified advance authorisations and EPCG authorisations expiring between March 1, 2026 and May 31, 2026 has been automatically extended up to August 31, 2026 without payment of composition fee,” the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT)



has said in a public notice.

Under Export Promotion Capital Goods (EPCG) scheme, domestic firms are allowed to import duty-free machines but they have to meet certain export obligations against that.

This relaxation is in addition to the existing facility already available under foreign trade policy upon payment of composition fees, it said.

The exporting community was earlier grappling with high US tariffs and is facing challenges from the West Asian crisis triggered by the joint attack of the US and Israel on Iran last month. The conflict has led to disruptions in the movement of ships.

The conflict has also pushed up sea and air freight rates, while insurance premiums are also rising. If the situation persists, it could affect the price competitiveness of Indian goods in global markets. The commerce ministry said the extension shall be granted automatically, and exporters will not be required to submit any separate application or pay any composition fee to avail the benefit.

This measure has been introduced to provide additional operational flexibility to exporters facing disruptions arising from current geopolitical developments affecting global trade and logistics. PTI

Vedanta Power celebrates International Women’s Day with 29% women workforce

At Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd, women constitute about 52% of the workforce

NEW DELHI: Women professionals are increasingly contributing in core engineering and plant operations at Vedanta Power — from control systems to ash plants — the firm said ahead of International Women’s Day. The company said women now constitute nearly 29 per cent of its total workforce.

“Women professionals are increasingly contributing in core engineering and plant operations, including control and instrumentation systems, plant control rooms, ash and coal handling plants, water systems, and operations



and maintenance functions -- areas traditionally dominated by men,” the company said in a statement. The company said its Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd plant in Punjab has around 52 per cent women representation, reflecting one of the strongest diversity records in the coun-

try’s power generation industry. Vedanta Power’s other assets are also seeing increased participation of women, with Meenakshi Energy reporting 26 per cent women employees and Vedanta Ltd Chhattisgarh Thermal Power Plant (VLCTPP) at 19.5 per cent women represen-

At leadership level, women account for 27% of Vedanta Power’s executive leadership team

tation in FY26, the company said in a statement.

At the leadership level, women account for 27 per cent of Vedanta Power’s executive leadership team, leading key functions such as finance, human resources, safety, ESG & sustainability, it added. MPOST

NEW DELHI: India’s agricultural and food exports worth about \$11.8 billion to West Asia could face disruptions as the ongoing conflict in the region affects shipping routes, raises insurance costs and creates logistical uncertainty, think tank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said on Saturday.

In 2025, India exported agricultural and food products such as cereals, fruits, vegetables, dairy products and spices worth \$11.8 billion to West Asia, accounting for 21.8 per cent of the country’s total exports in this sector.

According to GTRI, the Gulf region has traditionally been a key market for Indian food exports due to its proximity and the large Indian diaspora. However, the conflict is

GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said rice shipments face the greatest risk. India exported \$4.43 bn of rice to West Asia last year, accounting for 36.7% of its global rice exports

now disrupting trade flows and increasing costs for exporters.

India exported \$7.48 billion worth of cereals, fruits, vegetables and spices to West Asia in 2025, with the region accounting for 29.2 per cent of India’s global shipments in this category.

Major exports include rice,

bananas, onions, vegetables, pulses, nuts, coffee, tea and spices.

GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said rice shipments face the greatest risk. India exported \$4.43 billion of rice to West Asia last year, accounting for 36.7 per cent of its global rice exports.

Gulf markets are therefore crucial for producers in states such as Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.

Other exports to the region included bananas worth \$396.5 million, onions and garlic valued at \$111 million, coffee worth \$240.7 million and tea shipments of \$410.1 million.

India also exported nutmeg, mace and cardamom worth \$295.5 million, spice seeds such as cumin and cori-

ander worth \$163 million, and ginger and turmeric valued at \$173 million.

Processed food, sugar and cocoa preparations accounted for \$1.35 billion, while fish, meat and processed products were valued at \$1.81 billion.

Dairy exports to West Asia stood at \$281.1 million in 2025, accounting for 28.9 per cent of India’s total dairy exports, while alcoholic and non-alcoholic beverages worth \$197.5 million were shipped to the region, representing 43.3 per cent of such exports.

GTRI said India’s agri exports have become increasingly dependent on West Asian markets over the past decade, making current disruptions a concern for exporters, farmers and food processors. AGENCIES

Peak power demand to be at 270 GW this summer: MoS Shripad Yesso Naik

NEW DELHI: India’s peak power demand is expected to reach around 270 GW this summer, and the ongoing West Asia crisis will not disrupt regular electricity supply, Minister of State for Power Shripad Yesso Naik said on Saturday.

Speaking on the sidelines of ‘Lineman Diwas’, Naik said the power sector is prepared to handle demand and ensure uninterrupted supply despite global energy uncertainties triggered by the conflict in West Asia.

“This is an emergency situation. There may be some impact here and there, but in the power sector we are moving ahead in a way that there will be no disturbance in supplies. Peak power



demand will be about 270 GW this summer,” he said.

The Ministry of Power had projected peak demand of 277 GW for the previous summer beginning April 2025, while the highest demand recorded in June 2025 stood at 242.77 GW.

According to government data, the peak power demand met last month rose slightly to 243.15 GW, compared with

238.06 GW in February 2025. The all-time high peak demand so far was about 250 GW in May 2024, while the previous record of 243.27 GW was recorded in September 2023.

Meanwhile, domestic LPG prices were increased by Rs 60 per cylinder on Saturday, the second hike in less than a year, as oil companies passed on part of the surge in global energy prices following the West Asia crisis.

Naik lauded linemen for ensuring uninterrupted power supply and urged strict safety compliance, including use of protective equipment, proper shutdown procedures and regular training to prevent accidents. AGENCIES

Iceland cos keen to increase collaboration in fisheries, clean energy with India: Envoy

India and the EFTA comprising Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway & Switzerland implemented Trade & Economic Partnership Agreement on October 1, 2025

NEW DELHI: Icelandic companies are keen to expand collaborations with Indian firms in sectors such as fisheries, clean energy and innovation, leveraging the recently implemented free trade agreement between India and the European Free Trade Association (EFTA), an official said.

India and the EFTA bloc — comprising Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland — implemented the Trade and

Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) on October 1, 2025.

Signed on March 10, 2024, the pact includes a commitment by EFTA nations to facilitate \$100 billion in foreign direct investment in India over 15 years, potentially creating about one million direct jobs.

India’s Ambassador to Iceland R Ravindra said the two sides will mark two years



since signing the agreement next week.

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘An Iceland firm has announced an investment of \$30 mn in an Indian company in fishery sector in Maharashtra’
- » ‘Collaborations (are possible) in biotechnology, clean energy, fishery, geo-thermal and innovations, they (Iceland firms) could use the Indian market to scale up’
- » India’s exports to Iceland stood at \$66 million in 2024-25, while imports aggregated at \$11 million

He noted that an Icelandic firm has already announced a

\$30 million investment in an Indian fisheries company in

Maharashtra, expected to create around 800-1,000 jobs in Aurangabad.

Ravindra said significant opportunities exist for Indian exporters in Iceland in sectors such as textiles, coffee and pharmaceuticals, while collaboration in biotechnology, clean energy, fisheries, geothermal energy and innovation could help Icelandic companies scale through the Indian market.

To explore business opportunities, an Indian industry chamber is expected to lead a delegation to Iceland in May.

India’s exports to Iceland stood at \$66 million in 2024-25, while imports were about \$11 million.

Under Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement, several Indian agricultural and food products, including rice, cane sugar, processed vegetables,

seafood and confectionery, can now enter Iceland duty-free.

Earlier, tariffs on these items ranged from 10 per cent to as high as 220 per cent.

The removal of tariffs is expected to open opportunities for Indian exporters in Iceland’s niche but high-income market, where imports of products such as rice, seafood, vegetables, sauces and processed foods are currently dominated by European suppliers. AGENCIES

CITY: Pg 5
‘Women in power must lift others’: CM Gupta



NATION: Pg 7
‘India’s rise unstoppable and it alone will determine trajectory of its growth’



FILM: Pg 16
Rise of the Female Protagonist



IRAN APOLOGISES TO NEIGHBOURS | TRUMP THREATENS HARD STRIKE

Day 8: War with no off switch

‘Russia provided Iran with information to help Tehran strike US military’

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: US President Donald Trump on Saturday vowed to hit Iran “very hard”, saying the US military is considering new targets in the country even as Iran’s president apologised for attacks on regional countries even as its missiles and drones flew toward Gulf Arab states.

The Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian’s apology indicated that Tehran’s political leadership could not exercise full command over Iran’s armed forces. He also rejected President Trump’s repeated demands for surrender.

President Trump said that US military forces have “knocked out 42 Iranian navy ships” in three days, adding that the US is doing “very well” in Iran. Shortly after Pezeshkian’s message, Trump warned in a social media post that more Iranian officials would become targets in the war, writing: “Today Iran will be hit very hard!” In his comments on his Truth Social website, Trump noted the apology by Pezeshkian.

“Under serious consideration for complete destruction



BATTLE ON

» The Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian’s apology indicated that Tehran’s political leadership could not exercise full command over Iran’s armed forces

» He also rejected President Trump’s repeated demands for surrender

» President Trump said that US military forces have ‘knocked out 42 Iranian navy ships’ in three days, adding that the US is doing ‘very well’ in Iran

» Saudi Arabia said it destroyed drones headed toward its vast Shaybah oil field and shot down a ballistic missile launched toward Prince Sultan Air Base, which hosts US forces

» IN DUBAI, SEVERAL BLASTS WERE HEARD SATURDAY MORNING, AND THE GOVERNMENT SAID IT HAD ACTIVATED AIR DEFENCES

and certain death, because of Iran’s bad behaviour, are areas and groups of people that were not considered for targeting until this moment in time,” Trump wrote, without elaborating.

Iranian President Pezeshkian, one member of a tripartite

India eyes more gas; nations offer supply

NEW DELHI: With India exploring alternative sources to further strengthen its energy security, countries like Australia, Canada and several others have offered additional gas supplies, official sources said on Saturday.

Citing the ongoing US-Israel conflict with Iran leading to the closure of the key shipping route through the Strait of Hormuz, sources said the passage is not the only route for India’s crude imports and asserted that the days of dependence on a single maritime choke point are long over.

They noted that supplies from Russia, West Africa, the Americas, Central Asia, and now-Gulf Middle Eastern routes have ensured that disruption in any single corridor results in a managed sourcing adjustment, rather than a supply emergency.

Only around 40 per cent of India’s crude imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, they said. **See P2**

Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, delivered the defiant message exactly one week into a conflict that has spread across the region, rattled global markets and air travel and left Iran’s own leadership greatly weakened by hundreds of Israeli and American airstrikes.

The message, seemingly filmed in a hurry without professional broadcast equipment, again underlined the limited powers being exercised by theocracy’s leaders over its paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, which controls the ballistic missiles targeting Israel and others. It answered only to Khamenei and now appears to be picking its own targets as the conflict widens.

While the Iranian president attempted to assuage growing Gulf Arab anger over the attacks, just hours earlier, a wave of missiles and drones had disrupted flights at Dubai International Airport, targeted a major Saudi oil facility and sent people fleeing for cover multiple times in Bahrain.

There was no foreseeable end to the fighting. **Continued on P6**

LPG dearer by Rs 60; petrol, diesel spared

LPG Price Hike			₹ Per Cylinder		
Effective March 7, 2026					
Non-Subsidised for Domestic Use (14.2 Kg Cylinder)			Commercial Use (19 kg Cylinder)		
Delhi			Delhi		
Old	New	Change	Old	New	Change
853	913	▲ 60	1,768.5	1,883.0	▲ 114.5
Kolkata			Kolkata		
Old	New	Change	Old	New	Change
879	939	▲ 60	1,875.5	1,990.0	▲ 114.5
Mumbai			Mumbai		
Old	New	Change	Old	New	Change
852.5	912.5	▲ 60	1,720.5	1,835.0	▲ 114.5
Chennai			Chennai		
Old	New	Change	Old	New	Change
868.5	928.5	▲ 60	1,929.0	2,043.5	▲ 114.5

Source: IOCL.com KBK Infographics

‘India’s LPG among cheapest globally’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid ongoing conflict in the Middle East, the prices of domestic LPG and commercial cylinders have been hiked by a steep Rs 60 and Rs 114.5, respectively, from Saturday.

This is the second price hike in less than a year. Government sources said the revision comes after a sharp jump in global energy prices since the military conflict between the United States and Israel against Iran began in West Asia.

Sources, however, added that an increase in petrol and diesel prices is not in the offing as state-owned oil firms have enough financial muscle to absorb the warranted increase.

Rs 300 per bottle they get for up to 12 refills in a year.

Government sources said the increase was necessitated because of a spike in global energy prices. Despite the increase, the price is less than the Rs 1,050 per 14.2-kg cylinder rate required to break-even at cost.

They said considering an average consumption of 4-5 cylinders per year per household, the increase translates to 80 paise per day for a family of four or just 20 paise per person. Even at the increased prices, LPG in India is cheaper than **Continued on P6**

KITCHEN SHOCK

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Hope India wins T20 World Cup by comfortable margin

Omar Abdullah

In today’s paper ...

BUSINESS	
CANADA, AUSTRALIA OFFER EXTRA GAS 2	
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NATION	
MANN UNVEILS NEW INDUSTRIAL POLICY 7	
SPORT	
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INTERNATIONAL	
DOZENS KILLED IN LEBANON 10	

CBI TO MOVE SUPREME COURT

HC acquits Dera chief in scribe murder case

NARESH BISWANI



CHANDIGARH: In a major development, the Punjab and Haryana High Court on Saturday acquitted Dera Sacha Sauda chief Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh in the murder case of journalist Ram Chander Chhatrapati, more than seven years after he was convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment.

A division bench of Chief Justice Sheel Nagu and Justice Vikram Aggarwal set aside the 2019 conviction of Ram Rahim while hearing appeals filed against the verdict of the special CBI court in Panchkula. The bench allowed the appeal filed by the Dera chief and acquitted him of the charges in the case.

At the same time, the High Court dismissed the appeals filed by two other accused, effectively upholding the findings of the trial court against them. Ram Chander Chhatrapati, who ran a local newspaper in Sirsa, was shot outside his residence in October 2002 and later succumbed to his injuries. Sirsa is also the headquarters of the Dera Sacha Sauda sect.

The murder had triggered nationwide attention as Chhatrapati had published reports related to allegations of sexual exploitation inside the Dera Sacha Sauda **Continued on P6**

According to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the judgement will be reviewed, and a Special Leave Petition (SLP) will be filed in the Supreme Court

RSP SET TO FORM GOVT IN NEPAL

Ex-rapper Balen drops beat, beats PM Oli easily

KATHMANDU: RSP’s Balendra Shah on Saturday defeated four-time PM K P Sharma Oli by a huge margin and set to form the next government in Nepal, decimating traditional political parties in the first general elections since last year’s violent Gen Z protests demanding generational change and a corruption-free regime.

Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah ‘Balen’, the prime ministerial candidate of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) defeated Oli, the chair of Nepal’s legacy party, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist–Leninist) -- CPN-UML -- by a huge margin of about 50,000 votes in Jhapa-5 constituency.

Balen, 35, secured 68,348 votes against 74-year-old Oli’s 18,734, the Election Commission (EC) said.

The RSP, which was formed in 2022 by Ravi Lamichhane, has won 70 seats out of the 87 seats for which results have been declared by 8:30 pm, according to the Election Commission (EC).

RSP’s seats include a clean sweep in all 10 constituencies of Kathmandu district even as it is leading in 52 seats across the country, the EC data showed.

Legacy parties were far behind in convincing voters for whom the major issues included fighting corruption and an end to nepotism apart from a generational change in political leadership of the Himalayan nation.

The Nepali Congress (NC) won ten and was leading in nine seats; the CPN-UML won just three seats and is leading in eight; the Nepali Communist Party (NCP) won two seats and is leading in five, the Shram Shakti Party (SSP) was leading in three seats, and the Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) won one seat, the EC data showed. Among the winners is one independent.

Nepal witnessed about 60 per cent voter turnout during the March 5 elections to the House of Representatives. The counting of votes started late Thursday night **Continued on P6**



RAP TO RULE

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» RSP’s seats include a clean sweep in all 10 constituencies of Kathmandu district even as it is leading in 52 seats across the country

» Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday congratulated the people and government of Nepal for the successful conduct of elections

India secures best US trade deal, says Goyal

‘Both share powerful relationship’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India has secured the best trade deal with the US compared to its competing nations, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Saturday, noting that the two countries share a “very powerful” relationship.

He said that the US is the world’s largest economy - USD 30 trillion - and nobody can wish it away.

“It has been a fantastic journey. We have the best of relations. You would have observed that through the last year, President Donald Trump

has always had the best things to say about India as a country, and about Prime Minister (Narendra) Modi. We have fantastic relations with our counterparts there.

“Even within your family, sometimes you can have one or two misunderstandings. It’s a part of the course. I think it’s a very, very powerful relationship that the US and India share. And we got the best deal amongst all the nations with whom we compete,” Goyal said when asked about the trade relations with the US. He was speaking at Raisina Dialogue 2026 here. **Continued on P6**

PRESIDENT: ‘MAMATA, MY SISTER, MAY BE SHE IS ANGRY’

Mamata urges Prez ‘not to toe BJP line’, says ‘have respect for you’

MPOST BUREAU

KOLKATA/ SILIGURI: An exchange of statements between the President of India, Droupadi Murmu and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday sent ripples across the political spectrum, with PM Modi also posting remarks on his social media handle criticising the Bengal government.

While Droupadi Murmu questioned the change of venue for the tribal community programme and why neither the Chief Minister nor any other ministers were present to receive her, West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, stating her highest respect for the President of India, urged Murmu not to indulge in politics during elections, as allegedly advised by the BJP.

Reacting to the developments, PM Modi, in a post on X, said: “This is shameful and unprecedented. Everyone who



‘No protocol lapse happened’ on part of dist administration: CM

believes in democracy and the empowerment of tribal communities is disheartened. The pain and anguish expressed by Rashtrapati Ji, who herself hails from a tribal community, has caused immense sadness in the minds of the people of India. The TMC Government of West Bengal has truly crossed all limits.....” **Continued on P6**

Fuel price bomb in Pakistan

ISLAMABAD: In the first post-Iran war economic shock, Pakistan government in an overnight decision has increased petrol and high-speed diesel prices by PKR 55 per litre each, the highest-ever hike.

Addressing a press conference just before midnight, Petroleum Minister Ali Pervaiz Malik, Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar and Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb announced the hike with the consolation that the country has sufficient petroleum reserves.

As a result of the hike, the ex-depot price of high-speed diesel was fixed at PKR 335.86 per litre for the coming week, up by about 20 per cent from PKR 280.86 per litre.

Likewise, the ex-depot price of petrol was revised to PKR 321.17 per litre from PKR 266.17 per litre, reflecting an increase of around 17 per cent.

Malik said at the presser that the conflict in the Middle East created uncertainty in the entire region, offsetting global energy supply and prices, the Dawn newspaper reported.

“The fire that started in a neighbouring country has spread across the entire region. We do not know how long this crisis will continue, and there is no clear timeline for its end,” he said. He added that Pakistan was dependent on oil supplies passing through the Strait of Hormuz, which were affected by the ongoing conflict. **Continued on P6**

STOCKS TOTAL OVER 250 MN BARRELS

Amid turmoil, India has 8-week oil buffer

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Amid turmoil in West Asia, government sources said that India remains in a comfortable position on energy security and has a total of eight weeks of crude oil and petroleum products inventory, which includes strategic reserves.

They asserted that India holds over 250 million barrels of crude oil and refined petroleum products — approximately 4,000 crore litres. This translates into 7 to 8 weeks of buffer coverage across the full supply chain. These stocks are not held in a single location or a single form.

Only about 40 per cent of India’s crude oil imports transit through the Strait of Hormuz, significantly limiting exposure to regional disruptions.

The sources said India is closely monitoring developments in the region but is well-prepared to manage any potential supply-side challenges due to adequate inventory levels and diversified sourcing.

According to sources, India currently has around 25 days of crude oil inventory. Additionally, the country maintains about 25 days of petrol and diesel inventory.



STOCKPILE

» They asserted that India holds over 250 million barrels of crude oil and refined petroleum products combined — approximately 4,000 crore litres

» These stocks are not held in a single location or a single form

» Only about 40 per cent of India’s crude oil imports transit through the Strait of Hormuz, significantly limiting exposure to regional disruptions

Overall, India has a total inventory cover of nearly eight weeks of crude oil and petroleum products, ensuring energy security in the event of short-term disruptions.

Only 40 per cent of India’s crude moves through the Strait of Hormuz, and 60 per cent of the rest of the crude comes from other sources. India continues to import Russian crude as per previous contracts. The country is in a comfortable position with respect to LPG and LNG supplies, they added.

The government, according to sources, is keeping a close watch on the global energy market to ensure uninterrupted supplies for the country. Earlier in the day, sources indicated that India is scouting for alternative sources for **Continued on P6**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr.PC.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Chinna Devi** W/o Birender Kumar, R/o Tinku ka Makaaan, Lekh Ram Park, Tikri Kalan, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case FIR No. 718/2023 U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act. at P.S. Mundka, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Chinna Devi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Chinna Devi** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.PC. has been initiated in the case, Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Chinna Devi** accused of FIR No. 718/2023 U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act. at P.S. Mundka, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **16.04.2026**.

By Order: Shri Gaurav Singal,
Judicial magistrate First Class-06 (West),
Room No. 355,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi.

DP/2872/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely: **Abhimanyu Vohra**, Proprietor of M/s.Rajindra Enterprises, 5/117, Near Durga Store, Nirankari Colony, Delhi-09, Also at: N-12, Udhampur, Naveen Shahdra, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CC No.3435/2016 U/S 138 NI ACT registered at P.S Karol Bagh, Central District, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Abhimanyu Vohra** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Abhimanyu Vohra** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Abhimanyu Vohra**, accused of CC No.3435/2016 U/S 138 NI ACT, P.S Karol Bagh, Central District, Delhi is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before 05.05.2026.

By Order, URVI GUPTA
Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI ACT-01),
Central, Room No. 201, Annex-II,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi.

DP/2943/CD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sunil**, S/o Sat Narayan Sethi, R/o H. No. 204-D, K-5, Gali No. 10, Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 317/23, U/s 25/54/59 A. Act, P.S. Paschim Vihar East, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Sunil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sunil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sunil** accused of FIR No. 317/23, U/s 25/54/59 A. Act, P.S. Paschim Vihar East, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.04.2026.

By Order - Ms. Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11, West
Room No. 31, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/2963/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Naem @ Cheera S/o Azij Malik R/o Nithora Road, New Mustafabad, Nand Nagri**, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 12010/2023 U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Naem @ Cheera** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Naem @ Cheera** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Naem @ Cheera** of FIR No. 12010/2023 U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 27.04.2026

By Order,
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 19, First Floor, Shahdara District
DP/2869/NE/2026(Court Matter) Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Ishwar Singh S/o Sh. Mehar Ram R/o H. No. 41, Ground Floor, Near BSES Pole NJFH 034, Village Bamnoli, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case Ct. Cases 1165/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, PS Sector-23, Dwarka, New Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar Singh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar Singh** of Case Ct. Cases 1165/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, PS Sector-23, Dwarka, New Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated 08.04.2026

By Order
Harleen Singh
Addl. District & Session Judge
Court No. 609, South West Dist.
Dwarka Court, New Delhi

DP/2900/DW/2026

(Court Matter)

MODERN COACH FACTORY, RAEBARELI

Tender No.: FWP-TCover-Repair-165, Closing Date: 24.03.2026

Dy. Chief Project Manager-III/FWP, Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites **ONLINE** open tender based on Single packet system from reputed firms through Indian Railways portal www.irops.gov.in for Tender notice no. **FWP-TCover-Repair-165, Closing Date: 24.03.2026** on prescribed format for the under mentioned work:- **S.N.:1, Description of work:** Repair of Telescopic Cover of RQO-3, 4, 5, 6 & 7 machine (OP220.3, OP220.4, OP220.5, OP220.6, OP220.7) as per Scope of work, **Approx. Value (inr):** ₹8,17,150.00 (Eight Lakh Seventeen Thousand One Hundred Fifty rupees only) including GST @ 18%, **Security Deposit/Earnest Money:** ₹16,400.00 (Rs. Sixteen Thousand Four Hundred rupees only), **Cost of Tender document:** NIL (As per GCC For Works April 2022, Para-03 of Credentials of Contractors). **Note:** ● **Date and Time of closing of tender:** 24.03.2026 at 15:30 hrs. ● Detailed Tender Notice, Eligibility criteria, Terms & Conditions are available in tender document at Indian Railways portal: www.irops.gov.in **WM/Project/M&P (FWP)**

Serving Customers With a Smile

UJVNL LTD.

H.O.: 'UJVNL', Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508
CIN No.: U40101UR2001SGCQ25868, Website : <https://ujvnl.gov.in>

Letter No 196
SHORT-TERM TENDER NOTICE Dated 07.03.2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M) SHP, UJVNL Ltd., Rishikesh, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No. 23/EE(E&M)/SHP/Rishikesh/2025-26: "Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of 110V DC VRLA Battery Bank & DCDB at Urganm SHP (2 x 1500 kW), District Chamoli".
Estimated cost: Rs. 8,35,500/- (excluding GST)
Date of availability of bid document on website- 07.03.2026 from 16:00 Hrs.
Last date for submission of tender- 24.03.2026 up to 16:00 Hrs.
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "<https://ujvnl.gov.in>".

Executive Engineer (E&M-SHP), Rishikesh
"Avoid Wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Nitin @ Lucy S/o Ram Singh R/o:** H.No. A-290, Near Chaukhandi, Gurudwara, Tilak Nagar, Delhi Also At: T-96, Vishnu Garden, Delhi Also At: WZ 283/260, Gali No. 8, Vishnu Garden, Khyala, Delhi Also At: L 55, 3rd Floor, New Mahavir Nagar, Tilak Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 320/2019 Dt. 05.10.2019, U/S: 323/341/354D/509/34 IPC & 12 Pocco Act, PS: Khyala, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Nitin @ Lucy** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Nitin @ Lucy** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Nitin @ Lucy** of FIR No. 320/2019 Dt. 05.10.2019, U/S: 323/341/354D/509/34 IPC & 12 Pocco Act, PS: Khyala, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.04.2026.

By Order
Saloni Singh
Additional Session Judge-01 (West)
Pocco (FTSC) Room No. 21, Ground Floor
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/2972/WD/2026

(Court Matter)

Suryoday Small Finance Bank Limited

Regd. & Corp. office : 1101, Sharda Terraces, Plot 65, Sector - 11, CBD Belapur, Navi Mumbai - 400614. CIN: L65932MH2008PLC261472.

POSSESSION NOTICE

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the M/s. Suryoday Small Finance Bank Ltd., under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (ACT NO.54 OF 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(2) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a demand notice to the below mentioned Borrower/s / Guarantor/s. After completion of 60 days from date of receipt of the said notice, The Borrower/s / Guarantor/s having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower/s / Guarantor/s and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on them under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 6 & 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on the date mentioned herewith:

Name of Borrower/Co-Borrower/Guarantor	Date of Demand Notice	10.07.2025
237000020068, 1. MEENAKSHI BANSAL W/O MOHAN BANSAL, 2. MOHAN BANSAL M S/O KANWAR BHAN BANSAL.	Total Outstanding Amount in Rs.	Rs.58,07,403.82/- as on 08.07.2025
	Date of Possession	28.02.2026 (Physical)

Description Of Secured Asset(s) /Immovable Property (ies): ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL OF ENTIRE THIRD FLOOR (WITH ROOF RIGHTS), AREA MEASURING 32 SQ. MTRS. BUILT ON PROPERTY BEARING NO. 120, POCKET-8, SECTOR 24, SITUATION IN THE LAYOUT PLAN OF ROHINI RESIDENTIAL SCHEME ROHINI DELHI-110085.

The Borrower/s / Guarantor/s in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the M/s Suryoday Small Finance Bank Ltd, for an above mentioned demanded amount and further interest thereon.

Authorized Officer,
Suryoday Small Finance Bank Limited

Place : Delhi, Date : 28.02.2026

CLIX CAPITAL SERVICES PVT. LTD.

Registered Office: W/2/14, 1st Floor, West Patel Nagar, Delhi, 110008

"APPENDIX-IV-A" (See proviso to rule 8(i) Sale notice for sale of Immovable Properties)

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(i) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable property mortgaged/charged to the CLIX Capital Services Pvt. Ltd. (CLIX) (Secured Creditor), the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of CLIX Capital Services Pvt. Ltd. (CLIX), Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis on 10.04.2026, for recovery of amount as mentioned below, due to the Secured Creditors from following Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s). The reserve price and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned below respectively.

Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower/ Guarantor(s) with addresses	Description & Owner(s) of Properties
1. Mrs. Laxmi Devi W/O Krishan Kumar Sharma, 2. Mr. Rohit Sharma All That Piece And Parcels Of The Residential Property Situated At S/O Krishan Kumar Sharma, Both R/O 3542 Gurana Road, Gali No. 14, Baraut Mohalla, Basant Vihar Gurana, Gali No. 05 (From Sangam Baraut Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Cinema To Lord Mahavira School On Gurana Road, Entire Area On Both Ward No. 1, Baraut, Near Sarai Road, Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Sides Of The Road Within The Boundary Of Municipal Council Baraut Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Property In Nagar Palika Baru, Gurana Pargana And Tehsil Baraut District Bagpat, Admeasuring 33.45 Sq. Mtrs. Roadm Baraut Bagpat U.P. 250611. Loan No. - SN0HLM000707882 (First Floor Coverage 33.45 Sq Mtrs, Second Floor Coverage 18.58 Sq. Mtrs. Along with future interest and charges accruing after 14.10.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)	Hold Built Up Third Floor With Roof Rights Of Free WZ-18/8/105, Land Area Measuring 50.80, 3RD FLOOR VISHNU GARDEN, DELHI - 110018, ALSO AT: Sq. Yds, Out Of Kharsa No. 29, Plot No. 22, (Khasra No. 197) In The West Side Of The Road, Entire Area On Both Ward No. 1, Baraut, Near Sarai Road, Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Sides Of The Road Within The Boundary Of Municipal Council Baraut Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Property In Nagar Palika Baru, Gurana Pargana And Tehsil Baraut District Bagpat, Admeasuring 33.45 Sq. Mtrs. Roadm Baraut Bagpat U.P. 250611. Loan No. - SN0HLM000707882 (First Floor Coverage 33.45 Sq Mtrs, Second Floor Coverage 18.58 Sq. Mtrs. Along with future interest and charges accruing after 14.10.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)

Reserve Price (RP) & EMD & Incremental Amount	Recovery Amount as per Demand Notice	Date & Time of On-Site Inspection of Property	Date & Time of E-Auction
Rs. 31,50,000/-, Rs. 3,15,000/-, Rs. 10,000/-	Rs. 22,13,159.36/- as on 14.10.2025	08.04.2026 to 09.04.2026 From 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM	10.04.2026 11 Am to 1 Pm (with unlimited extensions of 5 Minutes each)

Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower/ Guarantor(s) with addresses	Description & Owner(s) of Properties
1. MR. SANJEEV KUMAR S/O MOHAN MANDAL, 2. MRS. ANJALI All That Piece And Parcel Of Build Up Third Floor With Roof Rights Of Free WZ-18/8/105, Land Area Measuring 50.80, 3RD FLOOR VISHNU GARDEN, DELHI - 110018, ALSO AT: Sq. Yds, Out Of Kharsa No. 29, Plot No. 22, (Khasra No. 197) In The West Side Of The Road, Entire Area On Both Ward No. 1, Baraut, Near Sarai Road, Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Sides Of The Road Within The Boundary Of Municipal Council Baraut Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Property In Nagar Palika Baru, Gurana Pargana And Tehsil Baraut District Bagpat, Admeasuring 33.45 Sq. Mtrs. Roadm Baraut Bagpat U.P. 250611. Loan No. - SN0HLM000707882 (First Floor Coverage 33.45 Sq Mtrs, Second Floor Coverage 18.58 Sq. Mtrs. Along with future interest and charges accruing after 14.10.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)	Hold Built Up Third Floor With Roof Rights Of Free WZ-18/8/105, Land Area Measuring 50.80, 3RD FLOOR VISHNU GARDEN, DELHI - 110018, ALSO AT: Sq. Yds, Out Of Kharsa No. 29, Plot No. 22, (Khasra No. 197) In The West Side Of The Road, Entire Area On Both Ward No. 1, Baraut, Near Sarai Road, Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Sides Of The Road Within The Boundary Of Municipal Council Baraut Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Property In Nagar Palika Baru, Gurana Pargana And Tehsil Baraut District Bagpat, Admeasuring 33.45 Sq. Mtrs. Roadm Baraut Bagpat U.P. 250611. Loan No. - SN0HLM000707882 (First Floor Coverage 33.45 Sq Mtrs, Second Floor Coverage 18.58 Sq. Mtrs. Along with future interest and charges accruing after 14.10.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)

Reserve Price (RP) & EMD & Incremental Amount	Recovery Amount as per Demand Notice	Date & Time of On-Site Inspection of Property	Date & Time of E-Auction
Rs. 24,57,000/-, Rs. 2,45,700/-, Rs. 10,000/-	Rs. 17,95,541.58/- as on 13.10.2025	08.04.2026 to 09.04.2026 From 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM	10.04.2026 11 Am to 1 Pm (with unlimited extensions of 5 Minutes each)

EMD amount shall be remitted through NEFT/RTGS/Funds Transfer in favor of "CLIX Capital Services Pvt. Ltd.", Account No. 341905000665, JCICIBANK, IFSC:JCIC0003419

Last date for deposit of EMD and uploading Bid documents: 09-04-2026 Till 12.00 PM at www.bankenauctions.in

The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of CLIX, as detailed above. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 15 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account, as detailed above. The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of CLIX, as detailed above. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 15 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account, as detailed above. The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of CLIX, as detailed above. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 15 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account, as detailed above.

Terms and Conditions:- E-auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" and "AS IS WHAT IS" and "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis and will be conducted "Online". The auction will be conducted through CLIX approved service provider C1 India Pvt. Ltd. at the web portal www.bankenauctions.in. Bid Documents, Declaration, General Terms and Conditions of online auction sale are available in www.bankenauctions.in. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer, there is no encumbrance on the properties. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of properties put on auction and claims regarding the properties, prior to submitting their bid. In this regard, the a-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of CLIX. For any details with respect to any help, procedure and online training in respect of the auction process please contact +91-7291981124/25/26 & E-mail id: delhi@clixindia.com. For any details regarding the property please contact Mr. Ayush Gupta, (M) 9999916811. It may please be noted that in case of any discrepancy/inconsistency between auctions notices published in English and in Hindi then the contents of the notice published in English shall prevail. The Authorized Officer/ Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in anyway for any third party claims/ rights/ dues. The sale shall be subject to rules/ conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002. STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002.

Date : 08.03.2026, Place : Bagpat, Delhi

Authorized Officer, CLIX Capital Services Pvt. Ltd.

CLIX HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

Registered Office: W/2/14, 1st Floor, West Patel Nagar, Delhi, 110008

"APPENDIX-IV-A" (See proviso to rule 8(i) Sale notice for sale of Immovable Properties)

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(i) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable property mortgaged/charged to the CLIX Housing Finance Limited (CLIX) (Secured Creditor), the constructive possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of CLIX Housing Finance Limited (CLIX), Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis on 10.04.2026, for recovery of amount as mentioned below, due to the Secured Creditors from following Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s). The reserve price and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned below respectively.

Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower/ Guarantor(s) with addresses	Description & Owner(s) of Properties
1. Mr. Haminder Singh, 2. Mrs. Ritu Chaudhary W/O Haminder Singh, Both R/O - All The Part And Parcels Of Arazi Kharsa No. 70/41/15 20/45 Block 20 Shakti Nagar New Delhi, New Delhi 110007. Also At: Mauza Saran, Situated In Mauza Saran, Tehsil Bahadurgarh, District Tehsil Bahadurgarh, District Fardabad, Haryana (Mct No. 446). Sr. No. 1 Also At: M/S-Fardabad, Haryana (Mct No. 446). Plot No 195 In The Housing Finance Limited (CLIX), Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis on 10.04.2026, for recovery of amount as mentioned below, due to the Secured Creditors from following Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s). The reserve price and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned below respectively.	Hold Built Up Third Floor With Roof Rights Of Free WZ-18/8/105, Land Area Measuring 50.80, 3RD FLOOR VISHNU GARDEN, DELHI - 110018, ALSO AT: Sq. Yds, Out Of Kharsa No. 29, Plot No. 22, (Khasra No. 197) In The West Side Of The Road, Entire Area On Both Ward No. 1, Baraut, Near Sarai Road, Baraut Po Baraut Dist Bagpat Sides Of The Road Within The Boundary Of Municipal Council Baraut Uttar Pradesh 250611, Also At: Property In Nagar Palika Baru, Gurana Pargana And Tehsil Baraut District Bagpat, Admeasuring 33.45 Sq. Mtrs. Roadm Baraut Bagpat U.P. 250611. Loan No. - SN0HLM000707882 (First Floor Coverage 33.45 Sq Mtrs, Second Floor Coverage 18.58 Sq. Mtrs. Along with future interest and charges accruing after 14.10.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)

Reserve Price (RP) & EMD & Incremental Amount	Recovery Amount as per Demand Notice	Date & Time of On-Site Inspection of Property	Date & Time of E-Auction with unlimited extensions of 5 Minutes each
Rs. 48,33,238 & Rs. 4,83,324/- & Rs. 10,000/-	Rs. 36,90,561.55/- as on 13.01.2024	08.04.2026 to 09.04.2026 From 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM	10.04.2026 - 10 Am to 12 Pm

EMD amount shall be remitted through NEFT/RTGS/Funds Transfer in favour of "CLIX Housing Finance Limited", Account No. 341905000665, JCICIBANK, IFSC:JCIC0003419

Last date for deposit of EMD and uploading Bid documents: 09-04-2026 Till 12.00 PM at www.bankenauctions.in

The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of CLIX, as detailed above. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 30 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account, as detailed above. The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of CLIX, as detailed above. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 30 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account, as detailed above.

Terms and Conditions:- E-auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" and "AS IS WHAT IS" and "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis and will be conducted "Online". The auction will be conducted through CLIX approved service provider C1 India Pvt. Ltd. at the web portal www.bankenauctions.in. Bid Documents, Declaration, General Terms and Conditions of online auction sale are available in www.bankenauctions.in. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer, there is no encumbrance on the properties. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of properties put on auction and claims/ rights / dues/ affecting the properties, prior to submitting their bid. In this regard, the a-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of CLIX. For any details with respect to any help, procedure and online training in respect of the auction process please contact Mr. Ayush Gupta, (M) 9999916811, E mail id: delhi@clixindia.com, for any details regarding the property please contact +91-7291981124 / 25 / 26. It may please be noted that in case of any discrepancy/inconsistency between auctions notices published in English and in Hindi then the contents of the notice published in English shall prevail. The Authorized Officer/ Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in anyway for any third party claims/ rights/ dues. The sale shall be subject to rules/ conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002. STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002.

Place : New Delhi, Date: 08.03.2026

Authorized Officer, CLIX HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice 10/2026 dated : 05.03.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

Tender No. : 13256057C	Qty : 1272 Nos
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Description : SS bench 304 grade as per RDSOs specification.

EMD (Rs) : 657800/-	Tender Opening Date : 27.03.2026
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Note : (1) The complete information of above E-Procurement Tender are available on IREPS website i.e. <http://www.irops.gov.in> (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tender. For this purpose, Vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with class III digital signature certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into financial rate page and duly signed digitally shall not be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight away ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed on their body. (5) Allocation for "Cost of Drawing" is Z-650 and for "Earnest Money deposit (EMD)" is Deposit Misc. stores-00844517. In case of any difficulty/helpdesk available on the IREPS website may be approached. 503/26 (C)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in CPRONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Aadil Alam S/o Md Faruk R/o 116, Veena Enclave Nangloi Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 587/2022 U/s 279/338 IPC at P.S.: Nihal Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Aadil Alam** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Aadil Alam** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Aadil Alam** of case FIR No. 587/2022 U/s 279/338 IPC at P.S.: Nihal Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 23.04.2026.

By order
Komal Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class - 03
West District, Room No.292, 2nd Floor,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/2887/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Harjeet Singh @ Jeet S/o Gannu Singh R/o Vill Agria Part-II, Green City, Tronica City, Ghaziabad UP** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 13319/2019 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: Welcome, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Harjeet Singh @ Jeet** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Harjeet Singh @ Jeet** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Harjeet Singh @ Jeet** of FIR No. 13319/2019 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: Welcome, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 08.04.2026.

By order
Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No.19, First Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/2534/NE/2026

COURT NOTICE (U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC) IN THE COURT OF Sh. Jogender Singh Civil Judge (Senior Division) Bhiwani

Mukesh Vs. General Public

CNR No. : HRBH02-000286-2026
CIS NO. SUCC/03/2026
Next Date - 24-03-2

‘Women in positions of power must lift other women’: CM Gupta

‘Must work together to ensure next generation of girls gets better opportunities’



Rekha Gupta poses for a selfie as she travels with Saheli Pink Card on a DTC bus on Saturday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said that capable women in positions of responsibility should help other women by providing the support and opportunities needed to move forward. Speaking at the ‘Bharati Naari to Narayani: National Convention of Women Thought Leaders’ organised by Rashtriya Sevika Samiti, Gupta said women must work together to ensure that the next generation of girls gets better opportunities. The CM said the country is progressing, and it is important that daughters receive the courage and opportunities that many women earlier could not get. She said women who are currently holding positions of responsibility should extend support to others who need guidance, resources and encouragement to advance in life. “When women hold each

CM checks implementation of Saheli Pink Smart Card

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday travelled in a DTC bus and interacted with commuters to inspect the implementation of the Saheli Pink Smart Card initiative. Launched by President Droupadi Murmu on Monday, the smart card allows women and transgender residents of the national capital to travel free of cost in Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses. The card has replaced the pink paper ticket and is expected to enable touch-free travel, maintain digital journey records and improve transparency in revenue accounting. “For the mothers, sisters and daughters of Delhi, this is an extremely convenient arrangement. This card is being made for free at various centres in the city. Just get yourself registered with your Aadhaar number and mobile number, and avail the benefit of free travel on DTC buses,” Gupta said. AGENCIES

L-G Sandhu recalls old times during visit to Moti Bagh gurdwara



Taranjit Singh Sandhu urged people to participate in city's development

NEW DELHI: Newly-appointed Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday visited the Moti Bagh gurdwara and offered prayers, reminiscing on his deep personal association with the area. Speaking with reporters, Sandhu said he had lived in the neighbourhood earlier during different phases of his life and used to visit the gurdwara regularly. “I used to live in this area when I was studying at JNU, and later stayed in Chanakya-puri at the accommodation for Ministry of External Affairs staff. After that, I lived in New Moti Bagh,” he said. Sandhu said both the New

Delhi hits 50-yr March high at 35.7 deg C

NEW DELHI: In an unusually hot start to March, Delhi on Saturday recorded a maximum temperature of 35.7 degrees Celsius, the highest reading logged in the first week of the month in the past 50 years, an IMD official said. According to weather data from the past 50 years, earlier the highest maximum temperature reading during the first seven days of March at Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, was 34.8 degrees Celsius logged on March 5, 1999. With the mercury touching 35.7 degrees Celsius on Saturday, it is now the hottest day in the first week of March during the 50-year period, the IMD official said. The IMD data 2011 onwards shows that the second-highest temperature reading during the first week of March was recorded in 2016, when the mercury settled at 33.6 degrees Celsius on March 4. Meanwhile, the city's air quality deteriorated sharply on Saturday. The 24-hour average AQI stood at 246 (‘poor’) at 4 pm, compared with 170 (‘moderate’) recorded at the same time a day earlier, according to Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB). AGENCIES

Woman falls off overcrowded train, dies

GURUGRAM: A 31-year-old woman died after allegedly falling off a moving train while standing at the gate due to overcrowding, officials said on Saturday. According to the Government Railway Police (GRP), the deceased woman was identified as Anchal Tyagi, a resident of Maksudpur in Noida. The victim was reportedly visiting her brother in Bhangrola village in Gurugram on February 9. On Friday, she boarded the Shalimar Express from Gurugram railway station with her mother Mamta to travel to Meerut. The train was very crowded, forcing her to stand at the gate of the compartment. When the train changed tracks, she lost her balance and fell off. AGENCIES



The grand finale of the 2nd All India Police Cricket Pilot T-20 Tournament 2025-26, hosted by Delhi Police, witnessed a thrilling contest between Maharashtra Police and Railway Protection Force (RPF) at the iconic Arun Jaitley Stadium. Winning the toss, the RPF team opted to field first. Batting first, Maharashtra Police delivered an outstanding performance and posted a massive total of 251 runs for the loss of 4 wickets, setting a challenging target of 252 runs for RPF. In response, the RPF team struggled against the disciplined bowling attack of Maharashtra Police and were bowled out for 160 runs, resulting in a comprehensive victory

DDA to manage flats from April 1

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will take charge of day-to-day maintenance of its residential flats from April 1, aiming to streamline upkeep and improve living conditions across its housing complexes. Under the new arrangement, DDA will handle routine services such as cleaning common areas, lift maintenance, security, lighting, and minor repairs. Residents will pay quarterly service charges, calculated per square metre, to cover these expenses. The authority will maintain flats until around 80% occupancy is achieved or a Residents' Welfare Association (RWA) is formed, whichever comes first. MPOST

REGISTRATIONS TO BEGIN FROM MARCH 9 Admission process for 12 special schools underway

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has initiated the admission process for 12 government and government-aided special schools for the current academic session, with online registration beginning on March 9. According to the Directorate of Education (DoE), the registration window for these institutions will remain open until March 17. The admission drive will cover classes from Nursery to Class X and Class XII in special schools functioning under the DoE. Parents and guard-

ians are required to submit and verify necessary documents at the respective schools between March 18 and March 23 during working hours. The department stated that allotment of schools to registered applicants will be carried out on April 1 based on the availability of seats, with the entire admission process to be completed by April 2. In instances where the number of applicants for a particular class exceeds the available capacity, selection will be done through a draw of lots. This draw, if required, will be conducted on March 24 at 11 am in the presence of school management committee members and parents, the DoE statement said. After verification of documents and completion of any necessary draw, heads of

schools will submit the final list of selected candidates to the Inclusive Education Branch headquarters on March 25. If seats remain vacant after the initial allotment, children on the waiting list will be admitted between April 3 and April 5 according to their position in the list, it said. These 12 schools provide specialised learning support and facilities for children with disabilities, including those with visual impairment and intellectual disabilities. The institutions follow specific eligibility criteria. AGENCIES

Uttam Nagar Holi victim was studying digital marketing to help family

‘Long-time neighbours were torn by persistent disputes’

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old man who died following a clash during Holi celebrations in southwest Delhi's Uttam Nagar had been pursuing a digital marketing course and hoped to support his family, his relatives said on Saturday, while demanding strict action against the accused. The deceased, identified as Tarun, died after sustaining severe injuries in the clash that was allegedly triggered by a dispute between two families from different communities over a balloon in the JJ Colony area on Wednesday, according to police. So far, seven people have been arrested and one minor apprehended in connection with the case. Tarun's father Memraj claimed that a balloon filled with coloured water accidentally fell on a woman from the other family, which started the initial altercation. “It was around 11 pm on Holi, and we were getting ready to sleep when they came to attack us. Earlier in the day, a little girl had dropped a balloon by mistake, and it fell on a woman from another community. They made such a big deal about it,” he claimed. According to Memraj, the woman later gathered her relatives, who allegedly came armed with sticks and attacked the family members. “They first attacked us, and we rushed to our homes. They then locked our gates from the outside. They were around 10 to 12 people.” Memraj said his son was pursuing a digital marketing course and wished to support the family. “He was our hope. He told us he would become our support,” he said. AGENCIES

Highlights

» The two neighbouring families apparently knew each other for the past five decades, and had persistent issues over parking and garbage disposal

» With the arrest of two more accused, the total number of people held in this connection has risen to seven, including six adults and a minor

DELHI METRO RAIL CORPORATION LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Majlis Park to Maujpur-Babarpur section of PINK LINE & Deepali Chowk to Majlis Park section of MAGENTA LINE will be opened for General Public from 3:00 PM onwards on 8th March, 2026 (Sunday)

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IMPORTANT PUBLIC NOTICE CONDUCT OF NATA 2026

The Council of Architecture shall conduct NATA 2026 from April 4 to June 13 2026, on all Fridays and Saturdays, at COA-approved Test Centres across the country for admission to the First Year of the 5-Year B.Arch. Degree Programme. NATA Tests held during this period shall be considered by various admission authorities for seat allotment through the Centralized Admission Counselling process. Candidates may appear in a maximum of two attempts during this phase. An additional NATA 2026 examination shall be conducted on August 7 & 8, 2026, exclusively for candidates who did not appear in the earlier phase. Such candidates shall be permitted one attempt only and shall be considered for admission against vacant seats remaining after completion of the Centralized Admission Counselling process. Registration for NATA 2026 will commence shortly at www.nata.in. Candidates are advised to visit the website regularly for updates and detailed information.

Who can apply?

Passed or appearing in 10+2 with Physics, Mathematics, and one approved subject as compulsory subjects, OR in 10+3 Diploma with Mathematics, securing at least 45% aggregate marks in each case.

The NATA 2026 brochure containing eligibility criteria, syllabus and other important details along with list of CoA approved institutions imparting B.Arch. program in the country shall be made available at www.nata.in and www.coa.gov.in.

NATA 2026 score shall be valid for academic session 2026-2027 only.

New Delhi Date: 08.03.2026

Registrar

DELHI POLICE SHANTI SEWA NYAYA

International Women's Day

Celebrating the Strength of Every Woman

FOR WOMEN'S SAFETY DELHI POLICE INITIATIVES

Women Help Desk 24x7 at All Police Stations

Women Helpline 1091

All Women PCR For assistance dial 112

Sashakti Self-defence workshop for women For self-defence registration visit : www.spuwac.in

Woman Commando SWAT

Helpline Against Obscene Call 1096

Committed Towards Women's Safety

Delhi Police remains committed to ensuring the safety of women at all times through its numerous initiatives, rapid response helplines, and vigilant patrol teams. On this International Women's Day, we reaffirm our dedication to safeguarding the dignity, confidence, and respect of every woman.

Your Safety is our duty. Your Trust is our strength.

24*7 Special Women Helpline 1091, 7835075012

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E-mail to CP, Delhi at : cpdelhi@delhipolice.gov.in | Write to : Cp. Delhi at P.O. Box No. 171, GPO, New Delhi

FOR IMMEDIATE POLICE HELP CALL 112 TO REPORT CYBER CRIME CALL 1930

DP/9867/2026

KHAMENEI WAS KILLED BY US & ISRAEL

Kashmir: Curbs on protests over Khamenei’s killing lifted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SRINAGAR: Life returned to normal across Kashmir on Saturday as authorities lifted restrictions which were in effect the whole week in the wake of protests in many parts of the valley following the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

“Restrictions have been lifted from all parts of the valley and the situation is normal,” officials said.

They said security forces have removed barricades that were put up at some places, including the Lal Chowk city centre here, to prevent the assembly of people.

The iconic Ghanta Ghar at the Lal Chowk had been sealed with barricades erected all around it after it witnessed massive protests on Sunday after Khamenei’s killing in a joint strike by the US and Israel.

Officials said shops and other business establishments reopened on Saturday morning in the Lal Chowk and other



Vehicles ply on a road after authorities lifted restrictions, which were in effect the whole week in the wake of protests in many parts of the valley following the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in Srinagar, Saturday

PTI

areas of the city and both public and private transport was plying normally.

Restrictions on mobile internet, which were imposed on Monday, and prepaid SIM card services were restored on Friday evening.

However, educational institutions continued to remain shut and are scheduled to reopen on March 9.

Officials said while barricades and most of police and

paramilitary CRPF personnel have been removed from across the city here, the situation is being closely monitored.

Authorities had on Monday imposed severe restrictions on the movement and assembly of people in parts of Kashmir where massive street protests were witnessed.

Kashmir, which has about 15 lakh Shias, saw major protests at Lal Chowk, Saida Kadal, Budgam, Bandipora, Anant-

Highlights

» The iconic Ghanta Ghar at the Lal Chowk had been sealed with barricades erected all around it after it witnessed massive protests on Sunday

» Authorities had on Monday imposed severe restrictions on the movement and assembly of people in parts of Kashmir

nag and Pulwama immediately after news of Khamenei’s killing spread.

The protesters were seen beating their chests as they shouted anti-US and anti-Israel slogans.

While the protests were by and large peaceful, a few places saw minor clashes between the security forces and protesters. Security forces had to use minor force to maintain law and order.

West Asia crisis: 52,000 Indians returned following partial opening of airspace

MEA urged all Indian nationals in the region to follow the guidelines of the local authorities and the advisories issued by the Indian missions

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Saturday said it is continuously monitoring the evolving situation in West Asia, especially in the context of the safety of its citizens stranded in the region.

In a late night statement, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said more than 52,000 Indians have returned to the country following the partial opening of the airspace across the region.

It also urged all Indian nationals in the region to follow the guidelines of the local authorities and the advisories issued by the Indian missions.

The safety and welfare of Indian nationals abroad is of utmost priority to the government and it remains engaged with the governments across the region to work towards facilitating all those in need of assistance, the Ministry of External Affairs said.

The security situation in West Asia remains precarious as the US and Israel continue



People, who were stranded in the Middle East due to flight disruptions amid the ongoing US-Israel-Iran conflict, upon arrival at Birsa Munda Airport, in Ranchi

PTI

their bombardment of Iranian targets while Tehran retaliates with strikes against Israeli positions and US military bases across the region.

“The government of India is continuously monitoring the evolving situation in West Asia and the Gulf region, especially with regard to the welfare of Indian nationals who

have been stranded there during transit or on short duration visits,” the MEA said.

“All Indian nationals in the region are advised to follow the guidelines of the local authorities as well as the advisories being issued by the Indian embassy or consulate in their location,” it said.

The MEA said Indian

From Page 3

Day 8: War with...

Trump’s administration approved a new USD 151 million arms sale to Israel after Trump said he would not negotiate with Iran without its “unconditional surrender,” and US officials warned of a forthcoming bombing campaign they said would be the most intense yet in the weeklong conflict.

Iran’s UN ambassador said the country would “take all necessary measures” to defend itself.

Associated Press video showed explosions flashing and smoke rising over western Tehran as Israel said it had begun a broad wave of strikes.

The fighting has killed at least 1,230 people in Iran, more than 200 in Lebanon and 11 in Israel, according to officials in those countries. Six US troops have been killed.

In a sign of the widening nature of the conflict, sirens sounded early Saturday in Bahrain as Iranian attacks targeted the island kingdom. And Saudi Arabia said it destroyed drones headed toward its vast Shaybah oil field and shot down a ballistic missile launched toward Prince Sultan Air Base, which hosts US forces.

In Dubai, several blasts were heard Saturday morning, and the government said it had activated air defences. Passengers waiting for flights at Dubai International Airport found themselves ushered down into train tunnels at the sprawling airfield after the alert sounded.

Later that morning, long-haul carrier Emirates said that “all flights to and from Dubai have been suspended until further notice.” Shortly after, the decision was reversed, and Emirates said the airline would resume operations.

Qatar’s energy minister, Saad al-Kaabi, warned in an interview with the Financial Times that the war could “bring down the economies of the world,” predicting a widespread shutdown of Gulf energy exports that could send oil to USD 150 a barrel.

The price for a barrel of benchmark US crude rose above USD 90 on Friday for the first time in more than two years.

Writing for the Qatar-funded satellite news network Al Jazeera, a regional analyst warned Iran was making “a strategic miscalculation of historic proportions.”

Sultan al-Khulaifi, a senior researcher at the Centre for Conflict and Humanitarian Studies, wrote: “By spreading the conflict to the Gulf, Tehran is doing precisely what Israel could not do alone: steering the war away from the Israeli-Iranian axis and transforming it into a confrontation between Iran and its Arab neighbours.”

LPG dearer by...

most countries in the world, they said adding cooking costs Rs 1,207 per bottle in Katmandhu, Rs 1,241 in Sri Lanka and Rs 1,046 in Pakistan.

Sources ruled out any immediate increase in petrol and diesel price as three fuel marketing companies - Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) with bumper profits in earlier this year - had enough financial muscle to absorb such impact.

Retail petrol and diesel prices have been on a freeze since April 2022, with fuel retailers absorbing losses when crude prices are high and making profits when rates are low.

Alongside, the price of commercial LPG - the one used by establishments such as hotels and restaurants - was increased by Rs 114.5 per 19-kg cylinder.

It now costs Rs 1,883 in Delhi. This increase comes on top of Rs 28 per 19-kg cylinder raise effected on March 1. Commercial LPG rate has risen by Rs 302.50 this year.

Since the conflict broke out on February 28, the US crude soared 35.63 per cent for the biggest weekly gain in the history of futures contract dating back to 1983.

LPG markets have also tightened as shipments from key Gulf exporters face logistical disruptions, pushing international propane and

butane benchmarks higher and raising concerns over supply availability for major importers such as India.

In Mumbai, non-subsidised LPG now costs Rs 912.50, Rs 939 in Kolkata, and Rs 928.50 in Chennai, according to the IOC website. Rates differ from state to state depending on the incidence of local sales tax or VAT.

The Strait of Hormuz is also a critical conduit for India’s energy imports, with roughly half of the crude oil the country buys from overseas transiting through the narrow waterway. In addition, nearly 40 per cent of India’s natural gas imports, largely in the form of LNG from Gulf suppliers like Qatar and the UAE, also pass through the strait.

India secures best...

The minister added that India and the US are strategic partners, and the two are the largest democracies in the world.

“We have a large responsibility cast on both our nations. They are the world’s largest economy, \$30 trillion economy, nobody can wish them away,” he said.

He said that ultimately a trade deal is about preference over competitors.

“What’s a trade deal? You are trying to get a preference or a preferential access for yourself, your goods, your services, compared to your competitor. And we got the best deal amongst all the competing nations. I mean whether it’s in our neighbourhood Pakistan or Bangladesh. If we look at the Asian region, we got the best deal amongst all of the competitors...” Goyal said.

He added that the India-US relationship is strong, multi-dimensional, and not only about trade as there is a huge technology overlay on it.

“There’s a huge critical minerals partnership, there’s a defense partnership, there’s a huge amount of investments that flow into India from the US. So it’s a partnership of two countries which is going to define the future,” he said.

These remarks are important as the two countries have finalised the framework for the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement. Under the deal, the US had announced to reduce reciprocal tariffs on India to 18 per cent.

However, following the US Supreme Court striking down the tariffs, Trump imposed 10 per cent tariffs on all countries from February 24 for 150 days.

A meeting between chief negotiators of the two countries to finalise the legal text for the agreement has been postponed.

Under the deal, India will eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of American food and agricultural products, including dried distillers’ grains (DDGs), red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products.

India has also stated that it intends to purchase USD 500 billion of US energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal over the next five years.

Talking about the nine free trade agreements (FTAs) that the Modi government has finalised, Goyal said the government has protected national interests, and has opened doors for Indian businesses.

“These nine free trade agreements, I can say on record with all the courage that I have on my command with all the responsibility that in not a single trade deal, has India compromised on any sensitivity of any of our stakeholders,” he said.

Opposition parties have alleged that the government has compromised the interests of farmers in the India-US trade pact.

He added that opening of the auto sector in some FTAs will provide choices to consumers in the country and create jobs. India has agreed to provide duty concessions in the sector under its trade pacts with the UK and European Union.

“Demand for this industry is growing at an average of 8 per cent. So you can imagine how much more scope we have to create jobs,” he said.

Goyal added that auto firms in the FTA partners may initially export cars to India to test the domestic market here, but once they “find the sweet spot of what sells in India, ultimately, they will have to manufacture in India.”

It will be difficult for expensive European cars to compete with Indian companies here.

“Initially they can sell, say, 5,000 cars or 10,000 cars, to test the market, find the distraction -- and then come and manufacture here,” he said.

He said the approach has been to create the worldwide web of trade partnerships through these FTAs.

Ex-rapper Balen...

and as of 5 pm Saturday, counting was in progress in 162 constituencies, the Election Commission said.

The election was being closely watched by India, which is hoping for a stable government in the politically fragile Himalayan nation to take forward the developmental partnership between the two sides.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday congratulated the people and government of Nepal for the successful conduct of elections.

“It is heartening to see my Nepali sisters and brothers exercise their democratic rights so vibrantly. This historic milestone is a proud moment in Nepal’s democratic journey,” Modi said in a post on X.

Modi also said that as a close friend and neighbour, India remains steadfast in its commitment to working closely with the people of Nepal and its new government to scale new heights of shared peace, progress and prosperity.

“Balen babu, congratulations for the victory,” Oli wrote in his social media post.

Oli, who too was projected as the PM face of the CPN-UML, wished Balen for a full five year tenure for his government in the Himalayan nation that has seen 14 governments in the last 18 years.

“I wish your five year tenure be trouble free, successful and hearty congratulations,” Oli said as he attached a 2022 photo showing him gifting a tabla to Balen after the rapper-turned-politician won Kathmandu mayor’s election as an independent.

The RSP, which projected Balendra Shah ‘Balen’ as its prime ministerial candidate and had organised its first election campaign in Janakpur in Madhesh, is heading towards a clean sweep of the province.

‘Balen’, as he is popularly known, projected himself as the “son of Madhesh” during the campaign, with the party launching the campaign with ‘Ab ki bar Balendra Sarkar’ (This time there will be Balendra’s government) tagline.

Of the total 32 seats in eight districts of Madhesh province, the RSP has won eight and is leading in 22 other constituencies, the EC said.

The party is also making a clean sweep in the Kathmandu Valley winning all 10 seats of Kathmandu district and two in Bhaktapur and one in Lalitpur district.

The party is also leading in the remaining two seats of the Kathmandu Valley with a huge margin, possibly as a result of a massive road show led by Balen in all 15 constituencies on the last day of the election campaign.

The 35-year-old engineer-turned-rapper-turned-politician is expected to be the next prime minister of Nepal, reflecting a public mood of rejection of established parties. Nepal has had 14 governments in the last 18 years.

RSP chairman Lamichhane won with a huge margin from Chitwan-2 constituency, marking his third consecutive victory with 54,402 votes against his nearest rival NC’s Mina Kumari Kharel, who received 14,564 votes.

According to the Election Commission, former prime minister and NCP leader Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda won from Rukum Purba district by securing 10,240 votes against his rival Lilamani Gautam of CPN-(UML), who got 3,462 votes.

RPP’s Gyanendra Shahi won from the Jumla constituency of Karnali province by defeating his closest rival Naresh Bhandari of the NCP and became the only candidate of the pro-monarchist RPP to have secured a seat in the House of Representatives.

Meanwhile, the RSP is also leading in proportional voting system with the party bagging 474,266 votes followed by Nepali Congress with 160,384. The CPN (UML) has received 127,841,

Nepali Communist Party 65,363, the RPP 34,154, and Shrama Shakti Party 17,437 votes till now.

Out of a total of 275 members of the Parliament, 165 are being elected through direct voting, while the remaining 110 through a proportionate method. Around 3,400 candidates were vying for 165 seats under direct voting, and 3,135 candidates for 110 seats through proportionate voting.

AGENCIES

Mamata urges Prez...

The whole situation stemmed from President Murmu’s media address on Saturday. While addressing a gathering of tribals at Bidhannagar near Siliguri after attending a programme at Goshapur near Bagdogra Airport earlier during the day, she wondered whether the Bengal Chief Minister was “upset” as neither she nor any state minister was present to receive Murmu during her visit to North Bengal.

The President also questioned the change of venue for the tribal community’s annual programme from Bidhannagar to Goshapur, where the turnout was reportedly low.

“Had the programme been held there (at Bidhannagar), it would have been better. There is ample space there, and many people could have attended. But I do not know why the state administration did not permit the meeting there. Today’s programme is being held at a place where it is difficult for people to come. Perhaps the state government does not want the welfare of tribals, and that is why they were prevented from coming here,” Murmu said.

Murmu also said Mamata Banerjee was like her “younger sister”.

When the President arrived at the venue on Saturday afternoon, only a handful of people were present. Siliguri Mayor Gautam Deb was the only representative present at the airport to receive her.

Reacting to Murmu’s remarks, TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee, from her sit-in demonstration, said: “I have respect for you, President Madam. But please do not play politics during elections as per BJP’s advice. You should know how many tribal people were affected under BJP’s rigged SIR exercise, how many of them were removed and what they have been forced to go through.”

“Look at the difference. See what we have done for tribal communities in Bengal, and then look at what has happened to tribals in many other states. And tell me something, when tribals were suffering during the violence in Manipur, when they were being attacked and humiliated, why did we not hear your voice then?” Banerjee asked.

“You (Murmu) have fallen into the BJP’s trap. BJP has brought the Constitution to such a low point that they are turning the President into their mouthpiece,” Banerjee said adding “Come once, we will receive you. What can we do if you come multiple times? I am fighting for the people whose names were deleted. People are my first priority but you are BJP’s priority.”

“I would urge you to refrain from making remarks that do not fit you. I don’t know who organised the programme,” Banerjee added.

Later, taking to the social media, Banerjee wrote: “International Santal Council, a private organisation, invited Hon’ble President to the 9th International Adivasi Santal Conference in Siliguri. After Advanced Security Liaison, district administration flagged in writing to the President’s Secretariat that the organiser appeared inadequately prepared; the concern was also conveyed telephonically (For relevant letters and photographs, see my related facebook post). The President’s Secretariat advance team visited on 05.03.26, was apprised of the lack of arrangements, yet the programme continued as scheduled.”

She added: “Hon’ble President was received and seen off by Mayor Siliguri Municipal Corporation, DM Darjeeling and CP Siliguri Police Commissionerate strictly as per the approved lineup shared by the President’s Secretariat. CM, West Bengal was not part of the lineup or the dais plan. No protocol lapse happened on part of district administration. BJP is disrespecting and misusing the highest chair in the country for its own party agenda. Most unfortunate.”

Amid turmoil...

importing crude oil, LPG and LNG. The sources said that there are no immediate plans to raise the prices of petrol or diesel in the country amid tensions in West Asia.

Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Puri, on Monday, reviewed the supply situation for crude oil, LPG, and other petroleum products with senior officials from the Ministry and PSUs, amid tensions in West Asia.

The Petroleum Ministry has said it is continuously monitoring the evolving situation, and all necessary steps will be taken in order to ensure the availability and affordability of major petroleum products in the country. India is a major importer of crude oil and natural gas from West Asian countries.

“We are continuously monitoring the evolving situation, and all necessary steps will be taken in order to ensure availability and affordability of major petroleum products in the country,” the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said in a post on X.

Moreover, the Department of Commerce, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, held a stakeholder consultation with all stakeholder ministries, key logistics and trade facilitation partners to review the emerging geo-political situation in West Asia and its potential impact on India’s export-import cargo flows, including the export ecosystem.

According to the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, the meeting was chaired by Special Secretary, Department of Commerce, Suchindra Misra and Lav Agarwal, Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT).

The meeting was attended by representatives from logistics operators and shipping lines/forwarders, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, the Reserve Bank of India, export promotion ecosystem and other concerned agencies.

Stakeholders presented an assessment of the evolving operational environment, including routing and transit-time changes, vessel scheduling adjustments, container/equipment availability, freight and insurance cost trends, and implications for time-sensitive exports.

“The discussions covered the need to maintain predictability in cargo movement, minimise avoidable delays, and ensure seamless documentation and payment processes for exporters and importers,” the Commerce Ministry said in a statement.

WITH AGENCIES INPUTS

Fuel price bomb...

The minister said that the government was monitoring the supply side and warned of strict action against hoarding and artificial shortages of petroleum products in the country.

He also shared that two Pakistani oil vessels were coming through alternative routes.

Malik said the government would now review petroleum prices on a weekly basis in view of the volatile international market.

HC acquits Dera...

against Ram Rahim.

According to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the judgement will be reviewed, and a Special Leave Petition (SLP) will be filed in the Supreme Court.

The case had been handed over to the CBI, which had conducted a thorough investigation and charged Ram Rahim and the other suspects with conspiring to murder the journalist.

In January 2019, the special CBI court in Panchkula had convicted Ram Rahim and the other three suspects, including Kuldeep Singh, Nirmal Singh, and Krishan Lal, and had given them a life sentence, as they were found guilty in the murder of the journalist.

Even though the High Court had acquitted Ram Rahim, the convict is currently in jail due to the other criminal convictions against him.

JAISHANKAR AT RAISINA DIALOGUE 2026

‘India’s rise unstoppable and it alone will determine trajectory of its growth’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s rise is “unstoppable” and the trajectory of its growth will be determined by the country alone on the basis of its strengths and not by the “mistakes” of others, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Saturday.

Jaishankar’s comments at the Raisina Dialogue came two days after US Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau said that the US will not repeat the mistake of providing India the same type of economic advantages it gave China that helped Beijing become a key competitor of the US.

“When we speak today about the rise of countries... the rise of countries is determined by the countries. The rise of India will be determined by India,” Jaishankar said at the discussion on cooperation among countries of the Indian



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar speaks during a session on third day of ‘Raisina Dialogue 2026’, in New Delhi PTI

Highlights

- » Jaishankar also highlighted India’s growing role in the Indian Ocean as a net security provider
- » External affairs minister also confirmed India’s approval of urgent docking for an Iranian naval vessel, IRIS Lavan, in Kochi this week

Ocean region.

“It will be determined by our strength, not by the mistakes of others,” he said without naming any country.

Amid some concerns over the US strike on an Iranian warship off the coast of Sri Lanka three days back, Jaishankar also highlighted India’s growing

role in the Indian Ocean as a net security provider but at the same time noted that it doesn’t override the realities of the region.

In that context, he mentioned the military bases of Diego Garcia, Djibouti and Hambantota.

The external affairs minister

also confirmed India’s approval of urgent docking for an Iranian naval vessel, IRIS Lavan, in Kochi this week.

“We got a message from the Iranian side that one of the ships, which presumably was closest to our borders at that point of time, wanted to come into our port. They were

reporting that they were having problems. On March 1, we said -- you can come in. It took them a few days to sail in and then they docked in Kochi,” he said.

The Indian Navy approved the request to dock the ship, days before the US torpedoed and sank Iranian frigate IRIS Dena.

IRIS Lavan docked at Kochi on March 4. The vessel remains in Kochi with its 183 crew members currently being accommodated at Indian naval facilities on humanitarian grounds.

Jaishankar also emphasised the need to follow the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

While analysing the situation in the Indian Ocean region as well as the India growth story, Jaishankar said, “Those who work with us obviously will get more benefits; I’m not saying there are no challenges to India’s rise, there are.”

‘Cowardly & compromised’: Cong slams govt over US’ oil remark

‘Scott Bessent has given Modi government its certificate for faithfully following President Trump’s orders’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Key Points

- » Does anything more need to be said about how cowardly and compromised the self-proclaimed 56-inch chest has become?
- » After the US announced a 30-day waiver to allow Indian refiners to purchase Russian oil, BJP termed development a success of strategic oil diplomacy under Modi

US sanctions’ waiver allowing refiners to purchase it removes friction, it does not define the country’s policy.

Russian oil continued to flow into India even after the US objected to it and imposed sanctions, the functionary said, citing a 2013 adjustment done by the then Congress government in oil imports under US sanctions.

After the US announced that it is issuing a temporary 30-day waiver to allow Indian refiners to purchase Russian oil, the BJP on Friday had termed the development a success of the strategic oil diplomacy under Prime Minister Modi, and said it’s a “big egg on the face of anti-India Rahul Gandhi and the Congress”.

In an interview to Fox Business on Friday, Bessent said, “The world is very well supplied in oil. Yesterday, the Treasury (Department) agreed to let our allies in India start buying Russian oil that was already on the water.”

Chhattisgarh: 435 cr approved for 28,461 houses under PM Awas Yojana 2.0

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: Chhattisgarh has received a major boost in urban housing development as the Government of India has approved Central assistance of over Rs 435 crore for the construction of 28,461 new permanent houses under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (Urban) 2.0.

The approval by the Central Sanction and Monitoring Committee paves the way for large-scale housing construction aimed at ensuring “safe and dignified living conditions” for urban poor families.

The decision was taken during a meeting of the Cen-

tral Sanction and Monitoring Committee of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs on 23 February 2026.

With this approval, thousands of economically weaker families in Chhattisgarh will soon be able to realise their dream of owning a permanent home.

Across India, PM Awas Yojana (Urban) 2.0 is being implemented to fulfil Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of “Housing for All”. In Chhattisgarh, the programme is being executed actively under the leadership of Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai and the guidance of Deputy Chief Minister and Urban Administra-

tion & Development Minister Arun Sao, focusing on providing “affordable, secure and inclusive housing solutions” for urban residents.

Deputy Chief Minister Arun Sao has been regularly reviewing the progress of the scheme and instructing officials to expedite construction and ensure the transparent allotment of houses. These efforts aim to create a “simpler and more accountable system” for delivering housing benefits to eligible families.

The Central Sanction and Monitoring Committee approved 263 housing projects submitted by the state government.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HARIDWAR: Union Home minister Amit Shah launched and laid the foundation for public welfare schemes worth more than Rs 1,132 crore in Haridwar, Uttarakhand, marking a major milestone in Pushkar Singh Dhami’s four-year rule.

Union minister Ajay Tamta and several other dignitaries joined him for this occasion.

While addressing the public, Amit Shah said that this was not just a celebration of four years of Dhami’s rule but also nine years of his party’s rule. Shah said that this was a celebration of the long-fought free-



dom of Uttarakhand, referring to the firing incident at Rampur Tiraha during the statehood movement.

Shah said that Atal Bihari Vajpayee gave birth to Uttarakhand, but now PM Modi

Shah said that these schemes are a testament to PM Modi’s vision for Uttarakhand’s growth. Shah also said that these schemes are a symbol of his party’s rule in Uttarakhand.

Shah declared that the state has witnessed tremendous growth in recent years, and the last nine years have been the “golden era” for Uttarakhand. The projects announced will help Uttarakhand develop at an even faster pace, he said.

Shah also touched upon the criminal justice reforms and said, “These new laws are not only laws, but they are the modernisation of our laws, and justice will be delivered faster.”

Punjab CM unveils new industrial policy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUDHIANA: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday unveiled a new industrial policy here, asserting that his government is determined to make the state the number one investment destination in the country through bold reforms and a flexible incentive framework designed around the needs of industry.

He asserted that the Punjab government has fundamentally restructured its industrial policy to accelerate industrial growth, attract large-scale investment and generate employment across the state.

Empowered Women Nation's Pride



Heartiest Greetings on International Women's Day

Theme: Rights. Justice. Action. For ALL Women and Girls



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-Narendra Modi

State Level Programme

Chief Guest

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini

Chief Minister, Haryana

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March 8, 2026 | 1 PM | Chaudhary Devi Lal University, Sirsa

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Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana



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Final destination

T20 WC final: It's India's star power vs ruthless NZ machine at Motera

S KANNAN

AHMEDABAD: Men in Blue versus the Black Caps — not quite the script many imagined for the ICC T20 World Cup final. Yet here we are. As the two teams clash at the imposing Narendra Modi Stadium on Sunday, it may be tempting to label India the favourites on home turf. But that would be premature as Suryakumar Yadav's side prepares to face Mitchell Santner's men, who looked red-hot against South Africa in the semi-final.

Defending champions India began their World Cup campaign slowly before finding rhythm and peaking with a commanding performance against England in Mumbai. With both teams entering the final in strong form, the stage is set for a fascinating battle — flair versus consistency, star power versus ruthless efficiency.

In the build-up to the tournament, India enjoyed success against New Zealand in a bilateral T20 series. But that means little now. Sunday's marquee clash pits two balanced and battle-ready sides against each other. Bookmakers abroad may tilt towards India, but fans would do well not to get carried away.



India's Sanju Samson during a training session on the eve of the final

The Ahmedabad venue inevitably evokes memories of the heartbreak of November 19, 2023, when India lost the 2023 ICC Cricket World Cup Final to Australia at the same stadium. Yet dwelling on the past serves little purpose.

New Zealand have long proven themselves masters of big moments — none more so than their victory in the 2021 ICC World Test Championship Final under the astute leadership of Kane Williamson.

Santner's leadership reflects

1
India are the first defending champions of the men's T20 World Cup to reach the final

classic Kiwi traits — calm, pragmatic and ruthless when required. Unlike India, whose players carry huge star value through contracts and endorsements, New Zealand thrive on collective professionalism.

For India, confidence must not spill into overconfidence. The last two wins were impressive, but on a pitch expected to produce plenty of runs, India's batting must fire again. Questions linger around Abhishek Sharma's inconsistent form and the lack of a defining innings from captain Suryakumar Yadav. A single knock against the USA earlier in the tournament is hardly the standard fans expect from a player of Surya's calibre.

New Zealand's batting against India's bowling promises intriguing match-ups. Jas-

prit Bumrah remains India's spearhead with the white ball, but concerns surround the underwhelming performances of mystery spinner Varun Chakravathy. In the era of endless video analysis, decoding players has become easier than ever.

The much-discussed "mixed soil" pitch in Ahmedabad suggests a run-fest, which could spell trouble for bowlers hoping for assistance from the surface. Whether India stick with the same XI or make a bold tweak — perhaps bringing in Kuldeep Yadav — remains to be seen.

India's trump card lately has been Sanju Samson, whose back-to-back explosive knocks against the West Indies and England have turned him into the talk of the tournament. But India's hopes don't rest on him alone. Players like Ishan Kishan, Tilak Varma and Shivam Dube have all contributed when needed.

Then there is Hardik Pandya — the man for big occasions. Comfortable at this venue after captaining the Gujarat Titans in the IPL, Pandya's all-round abilities could prove decisive.

For New Zealand, several match-winners lurk in the shadows.

INDIA CHASE GLORY, KIWIS PLOT HEIST

Nerve, not noise, will decide the Ahmedabad showdown

MEENAKSHI RAO

AHMEDABAD: World Cup finals rarely belong to the team with the louder reputation. More often, they are won by the side that reads the moment better, adapts faster and holds its nerve longer.

That is the challenge awaiting India on Sunday as they face New Zealand in the T20 World Cup final at the imposing Narendra Modi Stadium — a contest that pits India's attacking depth against the Black Caps' trademark calm efficiency.

For India, victory would mean a historic second successive T20 World Cup title and another step in the evolution of a side that has rebuilt its identity around fearless but tactical cricket. Standing in the way is a team that has repeatedly upset stronger opponents on the global stage.

New Zealand's reputation as cricket's "nice guys" often masks their greatest strength — an ability to execute plans under pressure. They rarely panic, seldom lose tactical clarity and have repeatedly found ways to squeeze opponents in knockout matches.

Their semi-final victory over South Africa illustrated that perfectly. Chasing 170, the



NZ's Finn Allen bats at nets on Saturday as Tim Seifert looks on

Black Caps stormed to the target in just 12.5 overs, powered by Finn Allen's breathtaking 33-ball century. Allen's power in the powerplay has made him one of the most dangerous batters in the tournament.

Yet New Zealand's strength lies in depth. Tim Seifert provides stability at the top, Glenn Phillips offers explosive power in the middle order and captain Mitchell Santner brings tactical calm along with valuable all-round contributions.

India, however, arrive at the final with momentum and balance.

Their semi-final win over England at Wankhede Stadium showcased the resilience that has defined their campaign.

Axar Patel's stunning catches shifted the momentum in the field, Sanju Samson's composed 89 anchored the innings and Jasprit Bumrah sealed the match with a lethal spell of yorkers at the death.

Bumrah remains India's greatest weapon. Whether with the new ball or in the closing overs, his ability to deliver under pressure makes him one of the most decisive bowlers in the format. Alongside him, Arshdeep Singh has emerged as a reliable partner, swinging the new ball and striking regularly in the powerplay.

The Indian team management has also shown a willingness to make bold tactical calls.

ALL ENGLAND C'SHIPS

Victor Sen! Lakshya one win away from history



Lakshya Sen beat Victor Lai in three games

BIRMINGHAM: Battling painful blisters on his foot and severe cramps, a gritty Lakshya Sen overcame Canada's Victor Lai to storm into the final of the All England Open here on Saturday, moving within one win of ending India's 25-year wait for the prestigious title.

It turned out to be one of the finest matches of his career as Lakshya fought for one hour and 37 minutes before sealing a 21-16, 18-21, 21-15 win over the 21-year-old Lai, who had claimed a surprise bronze at last year's World Championships in Paris. It will be Lakshya's second appearance in the All England final after finishing runner-up at the 2022 edition.

The 24-year old from Almore will now chase history when he takes on world No. 11 Lin Chun-yi of Chinese Taipei in the summit clash on Sunday.

Prakash Padukone (1980) and Pulella Gopichand (2001) are the only Indians to have won the All England title.

Apart from them, only Prakash Nath (1947) and Saina Nehwal (2015 runner up) came close with runner up finishes.

Lakshya displayed immense mental fortitude, resolute defence and precise strokeplay as he endured punishing rallies clocking as many as 86 shots, against the dogged Canadian.

It will be Lakshya's second appearance in the All England final after finishing runner-up at the 2022 edition

"I was just taking one point at a time and starting up the third set I could feel a bit of cramps in the legs and I didn't know if I can go all the way," Lakshya said after the match.

"I was just trying to fight every point, fight just one more point and didn't think too much ahead," he added.

The contest opened with a bruising 52 shot rally, setting the tone for a gruelling encounter as the two shuttlers probed each other's defence with high tosses and sudden bursts of pace.

Former national coach Vimal Kumar was also all praise. "Lakshya, you have made us all incredibly proud. For me, the determination and resilience you showed today were truly unmatched. It was a physically draining contest of the highest intensity, yet you fought every point with remarkable courage," he said.

Women's hockey team eye WC berth

HYDERABAD: Under a new but familiar coach in Sjoerd Marijne, India will aim to secure a coveted berth at the upcoming FIH Women's Hockey World Cup when they open their campaign against Uruguay in the Qualifiers here on Sunday.

The tournament will feature eight teams -- hosts India, England, Scotland, Korea, Italy, Uruguay, Wales and Austria -- competing for three coveted qualification spots for the global showpiece.

At stake will be three direct World Cup berths, with the teams finishing first, second and third in the tournament earning direct qualification for the 2026 edition to be hosted jointly by Belgium and the Netherlands from August 14 to 30 alongside the men's event.

It will be Marijne's first assignment back as head coach, as the Dutchman returns for the second time since leaving the position after the team's historic fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021.

India are currently ranked ninth in the world and are the second-highest ranked team in the tournament behind England, who are ranked seventh globally.

Toor wins gold with 20m-plus throw

PATIALA: Indian Grandmaster Aravindh Chithambaram defeated Netherlands' Jordan van Foreest but world champion D Gukesh's winless run continued as he played out a draw yet again, this time against Vincent Keymer of Germany in the eighth and penultimate round of the Prague International chess festival here.

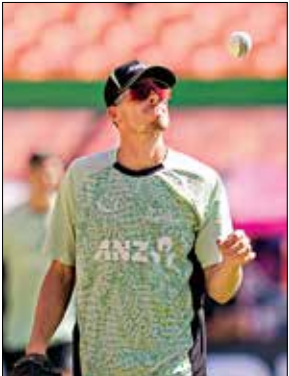
Uzbekistan's Nodirbek Abdusattorov leapfrogged to the pole position following a victory over local favourite David Navara.

With 5.5 points in his kitty, Abdusattorov enjoys a half point lead over van Foreest with just one round remaining. After winning

the Tata Steel Masters earlier in February, this could well be the second super-event win for the young Uzbek. Navara is the lone player on 4.5 points occupying the third spot while Aravindh moved to joint fourth spot on four points with Keymer and Parham Maghsoodloo of Iran.

Nodirbek Yakubboev of Uzbekistan, Hans Moke Niemann of the United States and David Anton Guijarro of Spain are next in the standings on 3.5 points, a point clear of last placed Gukesh. It was a lot of drama in the final stages of the day as Abdusattorov and Chithambaram both won from potential easy draws.

AGENCIES



“The only way to slow any team down is to get wickets at the top”

Mitchell Santner, NZ captain

seen as favourites, Santner insisted the tag means little to his side. "Everyone knows we're probably not the favourites, but we don't mind that," he said. "If we do our little things well and put together a strong team performance, it can put us in a pretty good position to hopefully lift the trophy."

Santner also predicted a high-scoring contest, suggest-

ing bowlers from both teams could face a difficult night.

"From what I've seen, it's going to be pretty flat and high-scoring," he said. "You're probably not rolling a team on a flat wicket for 160 — it might be more about turning a 250 into a 220."

India's formidable batting order has dominated much of the tournament, and Santner admitted early breakthroughs will be crucial.

"The only way to slow any team down is to get wickets at the top," he said. "If guys get away, it's very hard to pull them back without taking wickets."

The New Zealand captain also backed Indian spinner Varun Chakravathy, who has struggled recently, insisting the mystery bowler remains a serious threat.

"Everyone goes for runs on their day," Santner said. "But he's still a very good bowler and he's one game away from changing the narrative."

Ultimately, Santner believes the final will hinge on a handful of decisive moments — a hallmark of modern T20 cricket. "It always comes down to a couple of moments," he said. "If you can take those moments in a game like this, it can make all the difference."

As PSG's slide goes on, Enrique accepts his team is out of form

PARIS: Paris Saint-Germain coach Luis Enrique could only crouch down and watch as Monaco's attacks kept coming in waves, his players powerless to stop them.

After weeks of saying his team is attacking and defending better than last season, despite mounting evidence to the contrary, Luis Enrique's body language spoke for itself.

And afterward he simply could not gloss over Friday's 3-1 home defeat to Monaco in Ligue 1, which could have been far heavier given how easily the visitors' swift counterattacks pierced PSG's midfield and flanks.

"We were very imprecise for many parts of the match, we made some unusual mistakes. We made mistakes, a lot of mistakes," he said. "This is a crucial moment in the season, but it's up to us to turn things around, to regain our confidence. I want to be optimistic."

It was PSG's seventh defeat of the season in all competitions, and fourth in the past 13 games. Next up is Chelsea at home on Wednesday in the first leg of their Champions League last-16 game.

"What I want to say is that I don't want to lose faith in this team," said Luis Enrique, who



Annabel Sutherland brought up her fourth Test hundred

PERTH: Ace all-rounder Annabel Sutherland added two wickets to her hundred of rare quality to hand Australia firm control over India on Day 2 of the women's one-off day-night Test here on Saturday.

Sutherland smashed her fourth century (129 off 171 balls) in the last seven innings, third in a row, to guide Australia to 323 for an innings lead of 125 runs, and the hosts then reduced India to 105/6 at stumps.

Pratika Rawal (43) and Sneha Rana (14) were batting at the close. India still trail by 20 runs, as pacer Sutherland claimed the crucial wickets of

skipper Harmanpreet Kaur and Jemimah Rodrigues.

But Sutherland first pegged India back with the bat, getting a hundred in 133 balls through a swipe off pacer Kranti Gaud's short-pitched ball that flew over stumper Richa Ghosh for a four. The right-hander, who averages close to 90 across eight Tests, was at her best against pacers and spinners alike.

She was imperious against spin of Deepti Sharma, driving gloriously between cover and mid-off region, and when Gaud pitched it up to her, the 24-year-old was clattered the bowler through mid-wicket for a boundary.

Norris says F1 cars gone from best to 'worst'

MELBOURNE: Formula 1 champion Lando Norris is struggling with his new era McLaren car and frustrated to line up only sixth in Sunday's season-opening Australian Grand Prix.

Norris' title defence comes amid sweeping changes to the cars, and the 26-year-old British driver has endured a tough weekend at Albert Park so far.

F1's new cars are complex, with unprecedented changes across the chassis and power unit, which now feature an almost 50:50 output split between the turbo 1.6-liter V6 engine and electrical energy harvested from the brakes — one that requires a new, often counterintuitive driving style.

"We've come from the best cars ever made in Formula 1, and the nicest to drive, to probably the worst," he said after Saturday's qualifying.

He's not just coming to grips with his car's complex energy management systems, but also in getting out on track — with the Briton losing significant time in Friday's two practice sessions. "Just getting into the rhythm of lifting everywhere to go quicker and using gears you don't want to use and just understanding that when you lift more, you brake later but you have to brake less," Norris said.

LONDON: Eberechi Eze blasted Arsenal into the quarter-finals of the FA Cup on Saturday and kept alive the club's hunt for a quadruple of trophies this season.

Eze stepped off the bench and fired a thunderous effort into the top corner to see off the challenge of third-division Mansfield, sealing a 2-1 win at Field Mill.

Premier League leaders Arsenal are also into the Champions League Round of 16 and the English League Cup final. But it was given a stern test by a Mansfield team that is in the bottom half of League One and leveled the game in the second half through Will Evans.

On Friday, Scotland captain Robertson rifled in a low shot from outside the penalty box 10 minutes into the second half on Friday to put Liverpool



Liverpool's Mohamed Salah scores against Wolves

ahead and then Salah crashed home his enticing cross two minutes later.

Curtis Jones added a third for the visitor 16 minutes from time before Hwang Hee-Chan

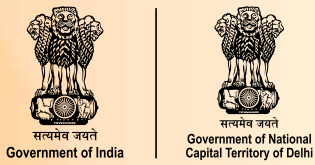
scored a stoppage-time consolation for Wolves.

Defender Robertson's only other goal this season came in September when Liverpool beat Atletico Madrid in the

Robertson rifled in a low shot from outside the penalty box and Salah crashed home his enticing cross

Champions League. His leading role in Friday's win was a welcome one after Wolves had humbled Arne Slot's team 2-1 in the Premier League three days ago.

"PSG drop points
Paris: Paris Saint-Germain dropped points in the Ligue 1 title race after losing 3-1 at home to a slick Monaco side.



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Shri Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



INAUGURATE

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- ◆ Deepali Chowk to Majlis Park Section of Delhi Metro Phase-IV (9.9 km Extension of Magenta Line)
- ◆ 2,722 Flats of 7 GPRA colonies at Sarojini Nagar and Kasturba Nagar
- ◆ GPOA at Netaji Nagar

and

LAY THE FOUNDATION STONE OF

- ◆ Ramakrishna Ashram Marg to Indraprastha Section of Delhi Metro Phase-V (A) (9.9 km Extension of Magenta Line)
- ◆ Tughlakabad to Kalindi Kunj Section of Delhi Metro Phase-V (A) (3.9 km Extension of Golden Line)
- ◆ Aerocity to IGD Airport Terminal 1 Section of Delhi Metro Phase-V (A) (2.3 km Extension of Golden Line)
- ◆ 6,632 Flats of 7 GPRA colonies at Netaji Nagar, Sriniwaspuri and Kasturba Nagar
- ◆ Bharat Business Park Commercial Complex at Sarojini Nagar

KEY FEATURES

Phase - IV Corridors

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- Advanced driverless trains ensuring more efficient operations
- Multiple interchange points for seamless travel

Phase - V (A) Corridors

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- Use of latest construction technology

Date

Sunday, 8th March 2026

Time

12:00 Noon

Venue

DDA Ground at Burari Road near Sant Nirankari Mandal, Delhi-110009

In the august presence of

Smt. Rekha Gupta

Chief Minister, Govt. of NCT of Delhi

Shri Manohar Lal

Union Minister of Housing & Urban Affairs and Power

Shri Tokhan Sahu

Union MoS of Housing and Urban Affairs

Shri Harsh Malhotra

Union MoS of Corporate Affairs and Road Transport and Highways

Shri Vinai Kumar Saxena

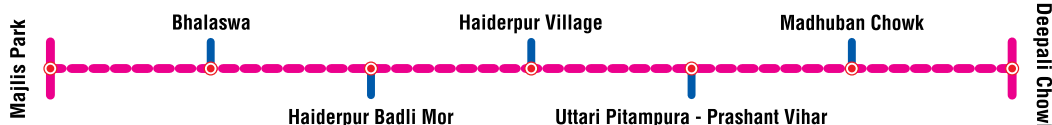
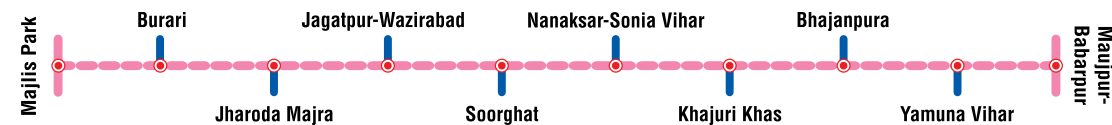
Lieutenant Governor, Delhi

Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh

Minister, Govt. of NCT of Delhi



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RAPPER-TURNED-POLITICIAN DEFEATS FOUR-TIME PM KP SHARMA OLI

Balendra Shah Nepal’s rising star in politics

KATHMANDU: Balendra Shah ‘Balen’, the rapper-turned-politician who won Kathmandu’s 2022 mayoral polls as an independent, has become the face of a generational change, symbolising a break from Nepal’s traditional parties.

Popular as ‘Balen’, the prime ministerial candidate of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) defeated four-time prime minister K P Sharma Oli, the chair of Nepal’s legacy party, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist–Leninist) -- CPN-UML -- by a huge margin of about 50,000 votes in Jhapa-5 constituency on Saturday.

The 35-year-old engineer was a popular choice to lead the interim government after Gen Z youths toppled the K P Sharma Oli-led coalition government in September last year, following two-day nationwide violent protests against corruption and a ban on social media.

But Balen declined then to lead the interim government, saying he would rather head the government by contesting the parliamentary election for



Balendra Shah greets a gathering at the EC premises on Saturday PTI

a full term.

In January, he joined the newly formed Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), led by Ravi Lamichhane, and was soon declared the party’s prime ministerial candidate.

As the Kathmandu Metropolitan City Mayor, Balen is credited with sweeping reform programmes and the beautification of the metropolis.

In his resignation letter, Balen said, as the Mayor of Kathmandu, “I have performed my duty in an honest manner as far as possible for the welfare of the metropolis and its inhabitants.”

Born in Kathmandu in a family originally from Madhesh province, Balen is the youngest son of Ram Narayan Shah, an Ayurved practitioner,

HIGHLIGHTS

» Popular as ‘Balen,’ the prime ministerial candidate of the RSP defeated KP Sharma Oli by a huge margin of about 50,000 votes in Jhapa-5 constituency

» The 35-year-old engineer was a popular choice to lead the interim government after Gen Z youths toppled the K P Sharma Oli-led coalition government in September last year

He married Sabina Kafle in 2018, and the couple has a 2023-born daughter.

Balen’s official YouTube page (@BalenShah with ‘Rapper, Lyricist, Music Composer’ as his description) lists about a million subscribers.

Balen released his first single song, ‘Sadak Balak’, in 2012, when he was one year short of his matriculation.

The very next year, he participated in a YouTube battle rap series, gaining widespread recognition across Nepal’s music lovers.

“His songs always reflect the ground struggle, social themes and raise issues such as corruption and inequality that matter the most for common Nepali,” said a college student.

It was this popularity that he capitalised on to enter politics and successfully contested the mayoral 2022 polls with his campaign slogan for ‘change’, targeting youngsters, most of them his followers on his social media platforms and were getting fed up with traditional parties’ musical chair politics.

No wonder, when K P Sharma Oli banned social media in Nepal in 2025, Balen was amongst the prominent voices to protest the move.

Earlier, months after he won as an independent, Balen was named in the ‘Top 100 Emerging Leaders of 2023’ by Time magazine, which described how he ran his campaign using multiple social media platforms “to harness voter anger over the status quo.”

“In a city still reeling from a deadly 2015 earthquake, Shah’s campaign promises were simple but offered desperately needed fixes: better waste disposal and sanitation, safe drinking water, clean roads, and the preservation of cultural heritage alongside urban development,” the magazine said.

However, his mayoral tenure was not without controversy. “He faced flak when there were widespread demolitions in the capital. He was also accused of not sending a fire brigade when Gen Z protesters resorted to arson,” said a critique.

MISSILE HITS BUILDING

Kharkiv: 10 killed in Russian strike



Firefighters put out the fire in a multi-storey apartment building following a Russian missile attack in Kharkiv, Ukraine, Saturday AP

KYIV: Two children were among at least 10 people killed on Saturday in a Russian missile that hit a five-story residential building in Ukraine’s second-largest city, Kharkiv, officials said. Sixteen others were wounded.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy condemned the attack and called for an international response. He said that Russia struck Ukraine overnight with 29 missiles and 480 drones, targeting energy facilities in Kyiv and other central regions and with damage reported in at least seven other locations across the country.

In the Kyiv region, damage from debris was reported in three districts, according to local authorities. In the southern Odesa region, 80 firefighters were called in to help battle massive fires at infrastructure facilities following an attack with multiple drones. Ukraine’s state rail operator Ukrzaliznytsia said damage to the rail infrastructure forced changes to a number of routes in the center-west of the country.

Russia’s Defense Ministry said the overnight strike targeted Ukrainian military factories, energy facilities and air bases. “There must be a response from partners to these savage strikes against life,” Zelenskyy said in a post on X. “Russia has not abandoned its attempts to destroy Ukraine’s residential and critical infrastructure, and therefore support must continue. We count on active work with the European Union to guarantee greater protection for our people. I am grateful to everyone who helps strengthen our protection.”

According to preliminary data, air defense systems downed 19 missiles and 453 drones with hits from 9 missiles and 26 strike drones recorded at 22 locations.

In Kharkiv, in Ukraine’s northeast, emergency workers were combing the rubble, looking for survivors. Among the dead was a primary school teacher and her son, a second-grade student, who were killed in their home and an eighth-grader who also died with her mother, according to the city’s mayor, Ihor Terekhov.

The regional Prosecutors’ Office said the building was hit by a new Russian cruise missile, known as Izdeliye-30. Ukrainian reports said that the new subsonic air-launched weapon that Russia has recently started to use against Ukraine has a range of 1,500 kilometers (930 miles) and is equipped with a new satellite navigation system more resistant to jamming.

Russia has fired tens of thousands of Iranian-designed drones at Ukraine since it invaded its neighbor just over four years. It has launched a large-scale domestic production of them and battered Ukraine with hundreds of drones in a single night — more than were used during some entire months in 2024.

Iran has responded to joint U.S.-Israeli strikes by launching the same type of Shahed drones at Middle East nations.

‘Enhance political loyalty’: Xi Jinping to PLA after purges

BEIJING: Chinese President Xi Jinping on Saturday called on the PLA to enhance political loyalty after the recent purge of the top brass of the military, while a top General called on the defence personnel to resolutely obey the Chinese leader’s command.

Meeting a largely condensed delegation of military officials of the People’s Liberation Army (PLA) and the People’s Armed Police Force at the National People’s Congress (NPC), China’s parliament, Xi stressed fully leveraging the unique strengths of enhancing political loyalty in the military, state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

He also called for concerted efforts to modernise national defence and the armed forces in a steady, sustained manner.

This was Xi’s first meeting after the removal of two senior Chinese military officials, including the highest-ranking PLA official, Gen Zhang Youxia, in January, regarded as a major purge of the PLA in recent history, sending shock waves among the rank and file.

Zhang Youxia was the Vice Chairman of the all-powerful Central Military Commission (CMC), headed by Xi himself.

After his removal, the six-member CMC, which is the overall high command of the Chinese military, has been reduced to two: Xi

This was Xi’s first meeting after the removal of two senior Chinese military officials

and Gen Zhang Shengmin, secretary of the discipline inspection body.

Significantly, Zhang Shengmin, the last standing General of the six-member CMC, in his speech at the current parliament session, called on the military to resolutely obey the command of Xi. “We must deepen political rectification, improve Communist Party conduct, fight corruption, and strengthen loyalty to the party’s core and resolute obedience to the command of President Xi Jinping.”

Zhang also called for more efforts to improve combat-oriented training and preparedness to safeguard national sovereignty, security and development interests.

It is also necessary to push for high-quality development, step up building integrated combat capabilities, strengthen the development and application of combat capabilities in new domains and of new qualities, and enhance military governance, Zhang was quoted as saying by the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post.

Lebanon: Dozens killed as Israel searches for signs of navigator missing for nearly 40 years

BEIRUT: An Israeli special force that landed in eastern Lebanon overnight in search of information about a navigator who has been missing for nearly 40 years did not find his remains, the Israeli military said Saturday. The operation left dozens of people dead and dozens more wounded.

Israel has been trying for decades to find out what happened to Ron Arad since he went missing after parachuting from a fighter jet that crashed in Lebanon in 1986. Arad was involved in attacking suspected Palestinian militants.

He was captured alive by local gunmen.

The Israeli military did not say where the force landed in Lebanon but the Lebanese army and state media said an Israeli commando force landed on the mountains along the border with Syria before heading to the eastern town of Nabi Chit, where they clashed with



People check the damage left by Israeli airstrikes, Saturday, in the village of Nabi Chit, eastern Lebanon AP

Hezbollah and local fighters. Lebanon’s Health Ministry said at least 41 people were killed and 40 wounded overnight in Nabi Chit and areas nearby.

The Lebanese army said three soldiers were among those killed in the exchange of fire. It said four helicopters took part in the operation, two of

which conducted the landing. It also reported that residents clashed with the Israeli force while Lebanese troops went on alert and fired light bombs.

A resident of Nabi Chit told The Associated Press that the Israeli force entered the town and dug up a grave in a cemetery before it left. The man who

spoke on condition of anonymity out of security concerns had no further details.

The Israeli army’s Arabic spokesman Avichay Adraee posted on X that the force did not find Arad’s remains or any evidence related to him.

Hezbollah said its members clashed with the Israeli force, and that Israel’s air force conducted some 40 airstrikes in the area in order for the unit on the ground to be able to withdraw.

Adraee said the Israeli force did not suffer any casualties.

A Shiite Muslim faction called the Believers’ Resistance captured Arad after he landed, and released some photos of him early on before all traces of him disappeared.

Arad was believed to have been held in Nabi Chit until 1988, after which he went missing following a fierce battle between Hezbollah fighters and Israeli troops in the village of Meidoun further south.

Ukraine’s low-cost ‘Shahed killers’ draw US and Gulf interest

KYIV: As the war in the Middle East strains US missile stocks, Ukraine is hoping it can turn a wartime innovation — low-cost interceptors designed to shoot down Russian attack drones — into geopolitical leverage.

Now one of the world’s leading producers of interceptors, Ukraine is offering that expertise to the United States and its Gulf partners for the war in the Middle East, hoping to receive in return the high-end weaponry it can’t manufacture at home.

When Russia launched its full-scale invasion four years ago, Ukraine’s domestic arms industry was poor. Forced to innovate to survive, it has since built a fast-growing defense sector centered on low-cost drones — some designed specifically to counter Iranian-style Shahed drones of the kind that Russia now launches by the hundreds.

The US recently requested “specific support” against Iranian-designed Shaheds in the Middle East, prompting Zelenskyy to order the deployment

of Ukrainian equipment and experts, though details remain classified.

When the war in Ukraine began in 2022, Kyiv banned weapons exports. But now Ukrainian manufacturers of low-cost interceptor drones say they are receiving interest from the United States and Gulf states. While other countries can build interceptor drones, Ukraine has the only mass-produced system already tested in war, Oleh Katkov, editor-in-chief of Defense Express said. “There is a huge differ-

ence between a mass-produced system proven to work in real combat and something others only promise to develop ... It’s like selling the house, not just the bricks,” he said.

If cooperation with partners succeeds, Ukraine could emerge as a new player in modern warfare, though it remains unclear whether its industry can scale up to meet that ambition or expand into global markets without compromising its own defense.

The surge in interest from the Middle East comes as Gulf

states burn through their stocks of expensive Patriot missiles, which they have been using to shoot down significantly cheaper Shaheds from Iran.

An Iranian-designed Shahed drone costs from roughly \$30,000, while a single interceptor missile for the US-made Patriot air defense system costs millions.

Lockheed Martin in a statement said it produced a record 600 PAC-3 MSE interceptors for Patriot batteries in all of 2025. Zelenskyy claimed Thursday that Middle East-

ern nations expended over 800 such missiles in just three days — more than Ukraine has held in reserve throughout the entire four-year war.

To counter the Shaheds, Kyiv developed low-cost interceptor drones priced at roughly \$1,000 to \$2,000, moving the systems from prototype to mass production within months in 2025. But Ukraine never developed a defense against ballistic missiles.

That’s why securing Patriot missiles remains a life-or-death challenge for Kyiv.

Minors among 33 injured in Peru nightclub bombing

LIMA: A bombing at a nightclub in Peru has injured 33 people, including minors, authorities said Saturday.

The explosion occurred in the pre-dawn hours at the Dali nightclub in the province of Trujillo along Peru’s northern coast, according to a statement from the local Emergency Operations Center.

It’s a region that has recently been plagued by violence and crime.

It wasn’t immediately clear who was responsible.

At least five of the injured are in serious condition, according to the executive director of the Trujillo Health Network, Gerardo Florián Gómez. Some of the victims suffered amputations and shrapnel wounds and are undergoing surgery, he told reporters. Among the injured are three minors: one 16-year-old and two 17-year-olds, Florián said.

The explosion occurred less than a month after another blast in the same city that damaged 25 homes but caused no injuries or fatalities.

Iran war: Trump administration, Democrats at odds over risk to America’s weapons stockpiles

Questions about US weapons stockpiles have grown as its campaign against Iran escalates

WASHINGTON: The US and Israeli strikes on Iran have raised concerns among Democrats and others about diminishing American stockpiles of certain weapons, illustrating a long-standing production problem that some experts say could present challenges if another conflict emerges.

The Trump administration has repeatedly said American forces have all of the weapons they need to fight the Iran war, now in its second week. President Donald Trump posted Friday on social media that several defense contractors had agreed to quadruple production of weapons “as rapidly as possible,” although he did not detail the specific systems being manufactured.

Questions about the nation’s weapons stockpiles have grown as the US campaign against Iran escalates, with many Democratic lawmakers arguing that Trump is waging a “war of choice.” Missile defense systems are under the most strain, according to experts, with Patriot and Ter-



minal High Altitude Area Defense, or THAAD, interceptors in high demand in Ukraine and Israel, respectively.

“I’m not particularly worried about us actually running out during this conflict,” said Ryan Brobst, a scholar focused on US defense strategy at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies. “It’s about deterring China and Russia the day after this conflict is over.”

The US is using both systems to take down Iranian missiles fired in retaliation for the American and Israeli attacks,

but US officials have said they are struggling to stop waves of drones launched by the Islamic Republic and that they are bringing in an American anti-drone system proven to work against Russian drones in Ukraine. The system known as Merops also is cheaper than firing a missile that costs hundreds of thousands of dollars at a drone that costs less than \$50,000.

Sean Parnell, the Pentagon’s chief spokesman, said in a statement that the US military “has everything it needs to

execute any mission at the time and place of the President’s choosing and on any timeline.”

Defense contractor Lockheed Martin posted on X late Friday that it had agreed to “quadruple critical munitions production” and “began this work months ago.” Trump and Lockheed did not offer a timetable of when the production increases would reach their target.

Some Democratic lawmakers, meanwhile, have questioned the long-term impact to the US and its allies.

KEY POINTS

- » The Trump administration has repeatedly said American forces have all of the weapons they need to fight the Iran war
- » Questions about the nation’s weapons stockpiles have grown as the US campaign against Iran escalates, with many Democratic lawmakers arguing that Trump is waging a ‘war of choice’

“We’ve been told again and again and again one reason that we can’t provide interceptors for the Patriot system or other munitions for Ukraine is that they’re in short supply,” Sen. Richard Blumenthal, D-Conn., told CNN on Thursday.

Sen. Mark Warner, D-Va., told reporters that American supplies are dwindling after the military fought the Houthi rebels in Yemen and engaged in more recent conflicts under the Republican administration. The top Democrat on the Senate Intelligence Committee did not specify what type of munitions he was referring to.

“Our munitions are low. That’s public knowledge,” Warner said. “It will require additional funding, funding where we have other domestic needs as well.”

Supplies of defense interceptors are the most taxed, said Brobst, who is deputy director of the Center on Military and Political Power at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a hawkish Washington think tank.

NAIROBI: Twenty-three people died, flights were disrupted, and the military was deployed as motorists in the Kenyan capital were stranded for hours on Saturday after roads were flooded following heavy rains overnight.

George Seda, the police boss in Nairobi, said Saturday that some of the people drowned and others were electrocuted, warning that the death toll may rise as search and rescue operations continue. Seda also said that more than 100 vehicles were damaged, with some overturning on the roadside and in parking bays.

Kenya Airways said Saturday that flights were disrupted, with some diverted to the coastal city of Mombasa, and that disruptions would continue for hours.

The military was deployed to assist emergency rescue services, and the local toll road operator waived fees for an elevated road.

Heavy rain began on Friday and continued overnight, submerging vehicles and forcing motorists in some areas to

The military was deployed to assist rescue services

wade through hip-high water to reach higher ground.

Videos of flooded homes and overturned vehicles were shared on social media.

A military rescue unit was deployed overnight to support emergency services as the Kenya Red Cross response units struggled to reach people in need. Kenya Red Cross Secretary-General Ahmed Idris said search and rescue teams were working tirelessly to assist those stranded.

“We are severely limited by the traffic and the situation on what used to be roads. We are doing our best to reach those in need,” he wrote on X.

Kenya’s Public Service Minister Geoffrey Ruku said Saturday that he was coordinating national disaster preparedness, response, and recovery efforts.

He urged Kenyans to be cautious and prioritise their safety.

HAD SURVIVED MULTIPLE ATTEMPTS IN PAST

UK’s most notorious child killers dies days after attack in prison

LONDON: One of Britain’s most notorious child killers died Saturday, days after he was attacked by a fellow inmate in the workshop of a maximum-security prison.

Ian Huntley, a 52-year-old former school caretaker convicted in 2003 for the murder of two 10-year-old girls, had been on life support after being hit repeatedly over the head with a metal bar at Frankland prison in northeast England on Feb. 26.

The murders of Holly Wells and Jessica Chapman had transfixed Britain for two weeks after the best friends vanished from the village of Soham in eastern England on Aug. 4, 2002 after leaving a barbecue to buy candy.

For 13 days, police searched for the pair, holding out hope they might be alive. A photo of the girls wearing matching red Manchester United soccer shirts, taken just before they disappeared, became a fixture of front pages and news broadcasts as detectives mounted a huge hunt.

Thousands visited Soham in an enormous outpouring of concern, leaving hundreds of bouquets outside the local church.

The search ended when a group of hikers discovered the girls’ remains beside a dirt path in a wooded area a few miles from the village.

“The murders of remains one of the most shocking and devastating cases in our nation’s history, and our thoughts are with their families,” the U.K. Ministry of Justice said in a statement.

Huntley denied murdering the two 10-year-olds, but was convicted after a trial at London’s Central Criminal Court in 2003. His life sentence recommended he serve at least 40 years.

While in prison, Huntley survived repeated attempts on his life, and he was kept under close protection along with



HIGHLIGHTS

» Ian Huntley, a 52-year-old former school caretaker convicted in 2003 for the murder of two 10-year-old girls, had been on life support after being hit repeatedly over the head with a metal bar at Frankland prison in England on Feb 26

» The murders of Holly Wells and Jessica Chapman had transfixed Britain for two weeks after the best friends vanished from the village of Soham in eastern England on Aug. 4, 2002

after leaving a barbecue to buy candy

» For 13 days, police searched for the pair, holding out hope they might be alive. A photo of the girls wearing matching red Manchester United soccer shirts, taken just before they disappeared, became a fixture of front pages and news broadcasts as detectives mounted hunt

» The search ended when a group of hikers discovered the girls’ remains beside a dirt path in a wooded area a few miles from the village

other notorious killers. In one incident in 2010, his throat was slashed by another inmate.

At the time of the murders, Huntley lived with Maxine Carr, a teaching assistant at Holly and Jessica’s grade school. Carr gave Huntley a false alibi and was subsequently jailed for 21 months for perverting the course of justice. She is now living under a new identity.

Huntley and Carr often spoke to reporters during the search for the girls. Huntley had told them he thought he

was one of the last people to see them alive, while Carr said she would always keep a card Holly had drawn for her.

British media have reported that murderer and rapist Anthony Russell, 43, was responsible for the attack that ultimately led to Huntley’s death.

Durham Constabulary are investigating the circumstances of the incident that led to Huntley’s death and a file is being prepared for the Crown Prosecution Service for consideration for charges. AGENCIES

Sri Lanka to repatriate bodies of Iranian sailors killed in US attack

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka will repatriate the bodies of the Iranian sailors who were killed on IRIS Dena, the first Iranian ship that was torpedoed by the US, the Deputy Defence Minister said on Saturday.

Sri Lanka said on Wednesday it had recovered 84 bodies of Iranian sailors after the US submarine attack sank the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena off Galle on the island’s southern coast.

The ship had been returning to Iran from Visakhapatnam, India, where it had participated in a naval fleet review exercise.

“The bodies are kept under refrigeration and action will be taken to send them back to Iran,” Minister Aruna Jayasekera told reporters answering a query here on Saturday.

The government maintains that the situation has not improved yet to try sending them by air or by sea.



Healthcare workers unload from a vehicle the bodies of Iranian sailors who died when their IRIS Dena warship sank outside Sri Lanka’s territorial waters, in Galle, Sri Lanka, Wednesday

The magisterial inquiry and the post-mortem on 84 bodies were concluded in the southern

port town of Galle on March 5. Eighty of the 84 were identified by the survivors.

Iran war: Trump to join slain soldiers’ grieving families

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump plans to join grieving families at Dover Air Force Base on Saturday at the dignified transfer for the six U.S. soldiers killed in the war in the Middle East.

The dignified transfer, a ritual that returns the remains of U.S. service members killed in action, is considered one of the most somber duties of any commander in chief. During his first term, Trump said bearing witness to the transfer was “the toughest thing I have to do” as president.

On his social media platform Friday night, Trump wrote: “I will be going to Dover Air Force Base tomorrow, with the First Lady and Members of my Cabinet, to pay our Highest Respect to our Great Warriors, who are returning home for the last time. GOD BLESS THEM ALL!”

Those killed in action were Sgt. 1st Class Nicole Amor, 39, of White Bear Lake, Minnesota; Capt. Cody Khork, 35, of Winter Haven, Florida; Chief Warrant Officer 3 Robert Marzan, 54, of Sacramento, California; Maj. Jeffrey O’Brien, 45, of Indianola, Iowa; Sgt. 1st Class Noah Tietjens, 42, of Bellevue,

KEY POINTS

» President Donald Trump plans to join grieving families at Dover Air Force Base on Saturday at the dignified transfer for the six U.S. soldiers killed in the war in the Middle East

» The dignified transfer, a ritual that returns the remains of U.S. service members killed in action, is considered one of the most somber duties of any commander in chief

Nebraska; and Sgt. Declan Coady, 20, of West Des Moines, Iowa, who was posthumously promoted from specialist.

The six members of the Army Reserve, who were killed by a drone strike at a command center in Kuwait, were all from the 103rd Sustainment Command based in Des Moines, Iowa, which provides food, fuel, water and ammunition, transport equipment and supplies. They died just one day after the U.S. and Israel launched its military campaign

against Iran.

“These soldiers engaged in the most noble mission: protecting their fellow Americans and keeping our homeland secure,” Republican Sen. Joni Ernst of Iowa, a combat veteran, said after the six were identified.

“Our nation owes them an incredible debt of gratitude that can never be repaid.” During the ritual, transfer cases draped with the American flag and holding the remains of the fallen soldiers are carried from the military aircraft that transported them to an awaiting vehicle to take them to the mortuary facility at the Delaware base. There, the service members are prepared for their final resting place.

Amor’s husband, Joey Amor, said earlier this week that she had been scheduled to return home to him and their two children within days.

“You don’t go to Kuwait thinking something’s going to happen, and for her to be one of the first – it hurts,” Joey Amor said.

O’Brien had served in the Army Reserve for nearly 15 years, according to his LinkedIn account, and his aunt said in a post on Facebook

that O’Brien “was the sweetest blue-eyed, blonde farm kid you’d ever know. He is so missed already.”

Marzan’s sister described him in a Facebook post as a “strong leader” and loving husband, father and brother.

“My baby brother, you are loved and I will hold onto all our memories and cherish them always in my heart,” Elizabeth Marzan wrote.

Coady was among the youngest people in his class, trained to troubleshoot military computer systems, but he impressed his instructors, his father, Andrew Coady, told The Associated Press.

“He trained hard, he worked hard, his physical fitness was important to him. He loved being a soldier,” Coady said. “He was also one of the most kindest people you would ever meet, and he would do anything and everything for anyone.”

Khork’s family described him as “the life of the party” who was known for his “infectious spirit” and “generous heart” and who had wanted to serve in the military since childhood.

“That commitment helped

Nigerian army kills 45 militants

ABUJA: Nigeria’s military killed 45 militants in the country’s northwest region, the Katsina state government said Saturday.

The clashes between the military and the gunmen happened on Friday in the Danmusa area of Katsina, the state’s Commissioner for Internal Security and Home Affairs Nasir Muazu said in a statement.

It followed a failed attempt by the gunmen to steal cattle on Thursday.

“Seeking revenge, the bandits returned in large numbers on March 6,” Muazu said. “What followed was an intense and fierce battle. The army successfully neutralized all 45 bandits.”

Nigeria is battling a complex security crisis from different armed groups, especially in the north of the country. AGENCIES

US: At least 4 dead as powerful storms rip through Michigan

LANSING: Four people were killed Friday in southern Michigan as powerful storms that produced at least one tornado, reduced homes to rubble, sent parts of roofs flying into the air and left a trail of debris hanging from power lines.

In the Union Lake area, near Union City, three people were killed, and 12 were injured after an apparent tornado hit, according to the Branch County Sheriff’s Office. About 50 miles (80.5 kilometres) southwest, Cass County officials reported one death and several injuries after a tornado touched down.

Lisa Piper stood on her back deck and videoed a terrifying scene that played out on the other side of frozen Union Lake as a funnel cloud formed and then dropped toward the ground. Trees were torn from their roots, and debris flew into the air.

“It’s lifting houses!” she said. As the devastation continued, she exclaimed, “Oh, my heart is pounding. Oh, I hope they’re OK!”

Powerful storms formed Friday from Michigan all the way to Oklahoma, with reports of heavy rain and threats of severe thunderstorms. Tornado watches stretched from Iowa to Oklahoma, along with Michigan.

At least one tornado has been confirmed in southern Michigan, near Union City, on Friday, according to the National Weather Service, and there were reports of possible others.

Part of the First Congregational United Church of Christ in Union City was damaged, although its nearly

The storms produced a tornado, reduced homes to rubble, sent parts of roofs flying into the air and left a trail of debris hanging from power lines

150-year-old grand piano was spared, it said in a post on Facebook.

The combination of a weather system that pulled moisture out of the Gulf of Mexico and a warm front that moved north created the right conditions for a tornado in a state where they’re relatively rare, according to David Roth, a meteorologist at the weather service’s Weather Prediction Centre in College Park, Maryland. The system encountered much cooler air in the Great Lakes area. Michigan gets an average of 15 tornadoes a year, which is much less than the 155 for Texas and 96 for Kansas, he said.

Gov. Gretchen Whitmer activated the state’s Emergency Operations Centre Friday “to coordinate an all-hands-on-deck response to severe weather,” she said in a statement.

In St. Joseph County, Michigan, next to the Indiana border, the sheriff’s office told residents to “seek shelter immediately” following reports of an unconfirmed tornado, a severe thunderstorm watch and possible winds of more than 60 mph (96 kph). AGENCIES

Christian worker tortured to death in Pakistan

LAHORE: A 21-year-old Christian worker was tortured to death allegedly by his employers in Punjab province of Pakistan, police said on Saturday. The incident took place in Sargodha district of Punjab, some 200kms from Lahore, on March 4.

The body of Markus Masih was spotted hanging in the cattle shed where he worked. His employers called the police and informed that he committed suicide for “domestic reasons”.

The cattle farm is owned by Muslim brothers, Muhammad Mohsin and Muhammad Basharat.

As police were initially reluctant to book both brothers in the murder case, the family and relatives of Markus blocked a main road in Sargodha demanding action against the alleged murder of Markus. On assurance of the police high-ups that an FIR would be registered against the suspects, the Christians ended the protest.

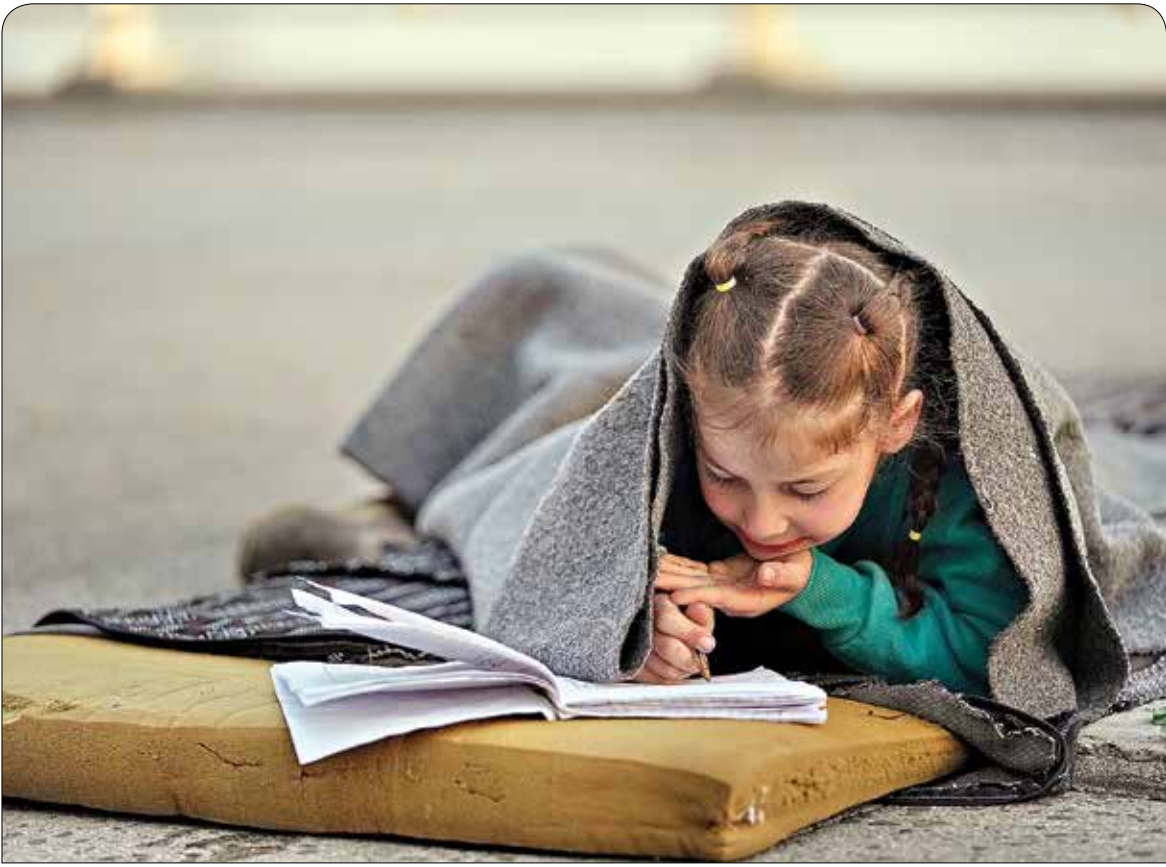
“First Information Report (FIR) has been registered against both brothers on the complaint of deceased’s brother Dilshad Masih under Section 302 (murder) of the Pakistan Penal Code,” a police officer said and added both brothers have joined the investigation and they would be arrested in light of forensic report.

Both brothers have been insisting that Markus Masih took his own life.

Dilshad Masih told police that the family found torture marks on the body of Markus.

“We strongly suspect that the employers had tortured Markus to death and staged the hanging to conceal their crime,” he alleged. AGENCIES

‘DISPLACED BUT NOT DISCOURAGED’



Hanaa, 7, displaced by Israeli airstrikes in Dahiyeh, Beirut’s southern suburbs, writes in a notebook while wrapped in a blanket in Beirut, Lebanon, Friday, March 6, 2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC /84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Junaid, S/o Furkan R/o H.No.C-53, Gali No.6/1, Mohan Puri, North Ghonda, Bhajanpura, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **e-FIR No.80071064/2025 u/s 305/331(3) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Junaid** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Junaid** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Junaid of e-FIR No.80071064/2025 u/s 305/331(3) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.04.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Preeti Rajoria
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class-07 (Central)
Room No.32, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/2960/N/2026

e-Procurement Cell ENERGY DEPARTMENT, GOVT.OF JHARKHAND Electrical Executive Engineer, Electric Works Division, Dumka

Short Notice e-Procurement Notice

e-Tender Reference No.- Energy/EWD/Dumka/35/2025-26 Dated-02-03-2026

Sl. No.	Name of work	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	Tender Fee (Bid Document Fee)	Bid Security (EMD Fee 2%)	Time of Completion
1	Provision of 106 Nos split type & cassette type Air conditioners in the Admin Building Ground Floor, Admin Building First Floor, Hostel Building, Hanger Building and Hospital at Air Port, Dumka, Jharkhand.	1,60,36,982=00	10,000=00	3,21,000=00	21 Days
2.	Date of Publication of tender on website	10.03.2026			
3.	Online bid submission period	From 11.03.2026 at 10:30 am to 16.03.2026 at 2:00 Pm			
4.	Technical Bid Opening Date	17.03.2026 at 3:00 Pm			
5.	Name and address of the office to inviting tender	Electrical Executive Engineer, Electric Works Division, Dumka			
6.	Name and address of the office to Open the tender	Electrical Chief Engineer, Energy Department, Ranchi, Jharkhand			
7.	Contact no. of Procurement officer	06434-291091			
8.	Helpline number of e-Procurement cell	06434-291091			

Note :- Tender Fee and Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) are to be paid through online mode only as per instruction of IT Dept. Govt. of Jharkhand Letter no.-120 Dated-03-10-2023. Further details can be seen on website-http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Electrical Executive Engineer
Electric Works Division
Dumka.
PR 374301 (Energy) 25-26 (D)



Some argue modern conflicts echo Crusades—medieval wars by Western Christians to control the Holy Land and assert dominance

Gulf on the Edge

From missile barrages to disrupted LNG exports, the US-Israel attack on Iran has unleashed a conflict that could reshape Middle Eastern geopolitics

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

an “overwhelming and decisive revenge” against those responsible for Khamenei’s killing. They announced that it would launch retaliatory attacks against Israel and US bases in the region. Since then, Iran retaliated by firing hundreds of ballistic missiles at Israel and US bases in Bahrain, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, Qatar and Jordan.

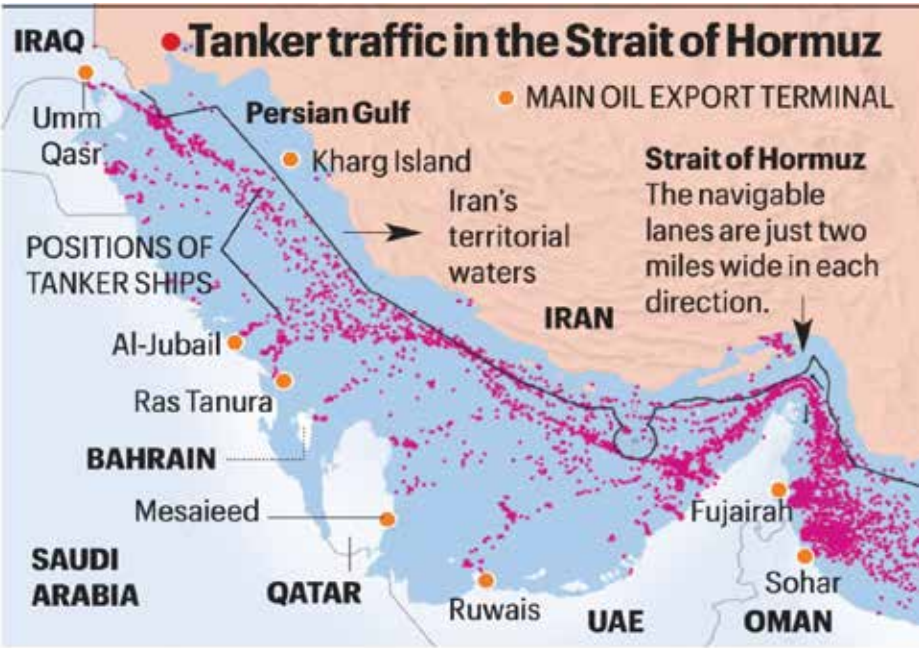
IRAN, SINCE THE ISLAMIC REVOLUTION

It may be recalled that in 1953, the US toppled Iran’s democratically elected Prime Minister, Mohammad Mosaddegh, who nationalised the Abadan Oil Refinery to take control of the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company (AIOC). The dethroned Shah of Iran, Mohammad Reza Pahlavi, was restored to power in 1953 by the USA.

In 1979, Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini returned to Iran after 14 years of exile in Iraq and France. Following a referendum, Iran was declared an Islamic republic. The 1979 Islamic revolution overthrew the monarch, Mohammad Reza Pahlavi. The US first imposed sanctions on Iran in November 1979, halted oil imports from Iran, and froze USD 12 billion in Iranian assets. Iranian products were banned from import into the US.

Despite nearly 47 years of US sanctions since 1979, the Islamic Republic of Iran has progressed in key development parameters. A comparative study of select development indicators, as tabulated below, reveals that the Islamic Republic of Iran, which had to fight a decade-long war with Iraq during the 1980s, progressed steadily during 1990-2023.

- In 2023, Iran achieved an HDI rank of 75 out of 193 countries and territories. Between 1990 and 2023, Iran’s HDI value changed from 0.626 to 0.799, a change of 27.6 per cent. Compared to Iran, Saudi Arabia’s rank was 37, and India ranked 130.
- In gender development index, Iran also fared better than India, though Saudi Arabia scored higher than Iran. Iran’s and Saudi Arabia’s life expectancy at birth in 2023



Note: Shows daily tanker positions from Feb1 to Feb15
Sources: The New York Times; Kpler, Marine Regions, Flanders Marine institute.



WHAT US 30-DAY WAIVER ON RUSSIAN OIL MEANS FOR INDIA

The waiver allows Indian refiners to buy Russian crude already loaded on tankers before March 5, 2026, and discharge it in Indian ports by April 4. With about 2.5–2.7 million barrels per day of India’s imports normally passing through the Strait of Hormuz, tapping floating Russian cargoes offers immediate supply relief.

were much higher than India’s in 2023.

- Very significantly, among the three countries, Iran’s achievement in female

education was better. Mean years of school for females in Iran in 2023 was 10.9 years compared to India’s 5.8 years and Saudi Arabia’s 8.4 years. Moreover, compared to males, the mean years of schooling of females was higher in Iran than in India and Saudi Arabia. The figure for India looks pathetic.- In gender inequality index, India scores marginally better than Iran, but Saudi Arabia has the best score among the three countries. Lower GII is considered better, which indicates reduced gender inequality. In the case of the maternal mortality ratio (deaths per 1,00,000 live births) in 2023, India registered 102.7 deaths compared to 22 and 16.2 in Iran and Saudi Arabia, respectively.

GULF STATES ON THE FRONT LINE OF WAR

Initially, Iran targeted the US military and strategic assets in the USA’s client states of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC): Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar,



The demand for Iran’s unconditional surrender is a dream they should take to their grave. Strikes against the US and Israeli assets will continue. So far, we have targeted every base that was the origin of aggression against Iran and we remain committed to this matter. Countries that have not provided space and facilities to the United States and the Zionist regime have not been our target so far and will not be targeted in the future.

MASOUD PEZESHKIAN
IRANIAN PRESIDENT

Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates. Iran has already struck at oil installations in Qatar, Bahrain, and Saudi Arabia. On March 4, Qatar Energy declared force majeure on LNG deliveries following Iranian drone strikes that forced a shutdown of its 77-million-metric-ton-per-year Ras Laffan export terminal. Three Amazon data centres in the Gulf have been hit in drone strikes, showing how such facilities are at risk of becoming wartime targets.

The CIA considers drinking water a “strategic commodity” in the Middle East, where countries rely on desalination plants for water supply. Iran has attacked a power station in the UAE that keeps a desalination plant running. Iran is targeting the Gulf’s image as a safe, prosperous hub for travel, tourism, and finance, and disrupting the oil and gas industry at its core. The Strait of Hormuz is closed exclusively to vessels from the United States, Israel, Europe, and their Western allies. India has received permission from the USA to import sanctioned Russian crude



for 30 days.

The European Union leaders have expressed support for Arab countries in the Gulf. France and the United Kingdom on Wednesday announced plans to send warships and air defence assets to Cyprus. Israel has expanded its military campaign to Lebanon, while the US on Wednesday sank an Iranian frigate in the Indian Ocean, killing dozens of unarmed people on board. The frigate was returning from India after participating in a naval show organised by India.

CHINA’S DILEMMA

Despite the existence of the Iran–China 25-year Cooperation Program, signed in March 2021, China has not offered Iran any concrete assistance other than diplomatic support so far. On Monday, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi spoke with counterparts from Iran, Russia, France, and Oman. Wang told Oman’s foreign minister that China supported Gulf nations in “safeguarding their sovereignty and national interests”, Wang said China was ready to play a “constructive role” in stopping the war.

In 2023, Riyadh and Tehran established diplomatic ties in an agreement brokered by Beijing, but their ties face the most severe test so far after Iran’s retaliation operation targeting the US embassy and a civil airport in Saudi Arabia.

China’s strong reliance on crude oil supplies from the GCC countries continues. It accounted for 36 per cent of China’s total crude oil imports in 2023. China has also been the GCC’s biggest trading partner for years, with the trading value reaching USD 288 billion in 2024. According to the South China Morning Post, Countries such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE are important buyers of Chinese semiconductors, and China’s 5G infrastructure has been steadily built in the region.

MENA REGION IN A DEEP CRISIS

Israel-USA invasion of Iran has put the Islamic countries of the MENA (Middle East and North Africa) region - Algeria, Bahrain, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, Jordan, Kuwait, Lebanon, Libya, Morocco, Oman, Palestine, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Tunisia, Turkey, United

Arab Emirates, and Yemen - in doldrums. The crisis is spreading fast across the globe.

With the fall of the Ottoman Empire after World War 1, the British and French carved up Ottoman lands for themselves. Saudi Arabia’s discovery of oil in 1938 brought the Kingdom immediately into contact with the United States. President Franklin D. Roosevelt began to pursue closer relations with the Saudi King Ibn Saud. The two leaders met in February 1945, marking an important start to a bilateral relationship that continues to this day. Since then, the USA has determined the politics and economy of the MENA region. After the formation of the State of Israel in 1947, the Zionist state became the USA’s collaborator.

Over the past several decades, the United States has conducted significant military interventions, including bombing campaigns and drone strikes, in cities across the MENA region, including Baghdad (Iraq), Beirut (Lebanon), and Damascus (Syria). MENA is the “cradle of ancient civilisation”. Mesopotamia (Sumerians, Babylonians), ancient Egypt, and the Phoenicians (Levant) - which later merged into major empires like the Persian and Ottoman - flourished in this region. While these actions were generally framed within the context of the “War on Terror”, regional stability, or opposing Iranian influence, they have often been analysed through the lens of Samuel Huntington’s (1993) “Clash of Civilisations” theory, which posits that post-Cold War conflicts are primarily cultural and religious rather than ideological.

Israel and the USA’s invasion of the Islamic Republic of Iran is justified, claiming that Trump was “anointed by Jesus to light the signal fire in Iran to cause Armageddon and mark his return to Earth,” reports the Independent. The religious wars waged between the 11th and 13th centuries, by Christians in the name of the Crusades, to seize the Holy Land, traditionally known as the Land of Zion, from Muslim control, are being re-established in the 21st century. The Modi administration’s alliance with Israel may be analysed from this common cultural stance.

SELECT DEVELOPMENT INDICATORS OF THE ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN, INDIA AND SAUDI ARABIA

INDEX/COUNTRY	IRAN		INDIA		SAUDI ARABIA	
YEA	2023	1990	2023	1990	2023	1990
HUMAN DEVELOPMENT INDEX[RANK]	0.799 [75]	0.626	0.685 [130]	0.446	0.900 [37]	0.670
GENDER DEVELOPMENT INDEX (GDI)	0.875	0.731	0.874	0.728	0.931	0.812
LIFE EXPECTANCY AT BIRTH (YEARS)	79.6 (F)	66.3 (F)	73.6 (F)	59.4 (F)	81.2 (F)	70.7 (F)
	75.8 (M)	62.1 (M)	70.5 (M)	58.0 (M)	77.1 (M)	67.3 (M)
MEAN YEARS OF SCHOOLING	10.9 (F)	4.6 (F)	5.8 (F)	1.8 (F)	8.4 (F)	3.5 (F)
	10.8 (M)	6.8(M)	8.0 (M)	3.6 (M)	9.2 (M)	6.9 (M)
GENDER INEQUALITY INDEX (GII)	0.482	0.666	0.403	0.697	0.228	0.780 *
MATERNAL MORTALITY RATIO	22.0	76.6	102.7	498.0	16.2	19.8

*For 2003 | Source: INDP Human Development Report 2025

INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY



160 YEARS OF COURAGE & COLLECTIVE AWAKENING

Born in labour struggles and suffrage movements, International Women's Day is both a celebration of progress and a reminder that the struggle for equality still continues

AMITABHA CHANDA

March 8 is not merely a date on the calendar – it is a living archive. It remembers smoke-filled factories, frost-bitten streets, hunger strikes, and handwritten petitions. It recalls women who marched when marching meant arrest, who spoke when speaking invited ridicule, and who organised when organising risked punishment. International Women's Day was not born in comfort. It was forged in resistance.

For more than 160 years, it has carried unfinished conversations between power and justice, law and lived experience, promise and reality. It belongs as much to the unnamed factory worker of the nineteenth century as to today's legislator, scientist,

and entrepreneur. From London to Petrograd, from India to Spain, from Singapore to Afghanistan, March 8 is both inherited and intentional.

The intellectual roots of this day stretch back to the French Revolution. As cries of *liberté, égalité, fraternité* echoed through Paris, women marched to Versailles demanding bread and justice. They were not spectators to history; they were its pulse. Yet the Declaration of the Rights of Man excluded them. Equality was proclaimed – but not applied. That contradiction between rhetoric and recognition would animate women's movements for generations.

Once women encountered the language of equality, they refused to relinquish it.

In 1857, women garment workers in New York City are said to have walked out of factories to protest long hours, unsafe conditions, and meagre wages. Though police dispersed the protest, the symbolism endured. The factories became classrooms of consciousness. Women learned that collective resistance was possible – that organisation itself was power. Labour rights and gender justice began to intertwine.

By 1908, more than 15,000 women marched through New York demanding better wages, shorter hours, safer workplaces, and, crucially, the right to vote. Economic justice without political voice, they understood, was fragile. The following year, the first National Women's Day was declared in the United States, marking a shift from spontaneous protest to organised strategy.

In 1910, at the Second International Conference of Working Women in Copenhagen, Clara Zetkin proposed an annual International Women's Day dedicated to suffrage and equality. Delegates from

17 countries endorsed the idea unanimously. Borders dissolved in that room. Women recognised that their struggles, though shaped by different contexts, were connected.

A year later, more than one million people rallied across Europe for women's rights. Around the same time, the "Bread and Roses" movement in the United States captured the ethical essence of the struggle: bread for economic security, roses for dignity and a life worth living. The demand was not merely for survival, but for meaning.

In Britain, suffragettes led by Emmeline Pankhurst intensified the fight. They chained themselves to railings, disrupted meetings, endured imprisonment, and undertook hunger strikes. Rights were not bestowed; they were wrested from indifference. After more than 10 years, by 1928, equal suffrage was achieved.

Then came March 8, 1917. Women textile workers in Petrograd struck for "Bread and Peace," igniting protests that would lead to the abdication of Tsar Nicholas II. Within days, women gained suffrage in Russia. A few moments illustrate more clearly how collective action can reshape history.

Over the decades, International Women's Day spread across continents. In China, it gained recognition as part of broader nation-building efforts. In Spain, it mobilises millions against gender-based violence and economic inequality. Singapore, Trinidad and Tobago, Afghanistan, and many other nations integrated March 8 into civic life, turning it into a platform for assertion rather than ceremony.

In 1975, the United

Nations formally recognised International Women's Day, linking gender equality to peace, development, and human rights. The day evolved from protest to global policy platform. Annual themes now address political representation, economic equity, climate justice, and digital inclusion. The moral appeal of March 8 found institutional expression. It started celebrating International Women's Day in 1977.

THE MARCH TOWARD JUSTICE IS FAR FROM OVER. BUT IT *continues* STRONGER WITH EVERY MARCH 8

India's engagement with women's rights runs parallel to this global journey. In 1917, Indian women petitioned for suffrage before colonial authorities. Social reform movements had already challenged child marriage and educational exclusion. At Independence in 1947, the Constitution granted universal adult franchise—an extraordinary democratic commitment. The 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments in 1992 brought millions of women into local governance, reshaping priorities in sanitation, health, and education. The Women's Reservation Act of 2023 marked another structural step toward inclusive representation.

Yet International Women's

Day is not only about milestones achieved. It is also about unfinished work.

Women today lead governments, command scientific missions, perform complex surgeries, negotiate treaties, and build transformative enterprises. At the same time, wage gaps endure. Violence persists. Representation remains uneven. In many parts of the world, access to education, healthcare, and digital tools still depends on gender. This is why International Women's Day remains both a celebration and a conscience.

The 2026 theme, "Give to Gain," reframes empowerment as collective progress. Investing in women—through education, mentorship, healthcare, and leadership opportunities – is not charity. It is a strategy. When girls receive education, economies expand. When women participate in governance, communities prioritise health and social welfare. When women lead enterprises, resilience deepens.

To give is to multiply. March 8 reminds us that equality is not inherited automatically; it is maintained intentionally. It remembers the smoke of 19th century factories, the marchers of 1908, the delegates in Copenhagen, the suffragettes of Britain, the strikers of Petrograd, the reformers of India, and the millions who continue to march today.

History is not merely observed. It is inherited.

And when women organise, speak, and lead, history moves. It moves steadily, sometimes slowly, often against resistance—but always forward. International Women's Day stands as enduring proof that courage and collective awakening can reshape societies.

Part II

SCIENCE, ECONOMICS AND CLIMATE FUTURES



Climate science and climate economics were once separate, but researchers now increasingly integrate them to design effective mitigation and adaptation strategies

KRISHNA GUPTA

Despite the differing worldviews of climate science and economics, considerable work over the past decade has sought to integrate the science with the economics of climate change. The development of Representative Concentration Pathways (RCPs) describes four alternative pathways with different levels of greenhouse gas emissions and radiative forcing that may occur in the future. Radiative forcing refers to the difference between incoming solar radiation and outgoing infrared radiation. These pathways project a broad range of forcing in the year 2100 of 2.6, 4.5, 6.0, and 8.5 watts per metre squared.

Another framework is the Shared Socio-Economic Pathways (SSPs), developed in 2016 by climate and energy scientists in collaboration with economists. Five such SSPs were developed, namely:

- SSP1 or sustainable development, which foresees few mitigation and adaptation challenges with low emission levels and low consumption. This is the ideal world.
- SSP2 or middle-of-the-road development, where the mitigation and adaptation challenges are limited and socio-economic and technological practices don't deviate too much from the past trends.
- SSP3 or regional rivalry, where national or regional nationalism takes centre stage, with rising barriers to international cooperation. Economic development is low, and inequalities worsen.
- SSP4 or inequality, where there are low mitigation challenges but high adaptation challenges. Rising inequalities within and across countries are foreseen, with the co-existence of a well-connected hi-tech section and a lower-income, poorly educated section working in a labour-intensive, low-tech economy.
- SSP5 involves fossil-fueled development, where there is all-around economic growth as well as investments in education and health and the ability to manage socio-economic as well as climate challenges.

The RCP and SSP were intended to be complementary and were included in the Coupled Model Intercomparison Project (CMIP) versions 5 and 6, respectively. The CMIP6 (CMIP is the comparison of outputs of hundreds of climate models from across the world) was included in the preparation for the IPCC's sixth assessment report.

The socio-economic conditions in the five SSPs

were, in turn, used as inputs into six Integrated Assessment models, which gave us different scenarios of how greenhouse gas emissions may vary in future and what steps need to be taken across sectors such as manufacturing, energy, urban and transport to meet mitigation targets. These emissions scenarios are then used in various General Climate Models (GCMs) and Earth System Models (ESMs), which give us different climate projections.

It is important to underline here that climate science can be an important input into climate economics and vice versa. While the climate science models tend to be more robust and adhere to physical laws, and take into account all possibilities of the uncertainties of climate, they are useful only to the extent that their findings can be used in policies of

CLIMATE CHANGE is no longer only a scientific question. It is also an economic and policy challenge

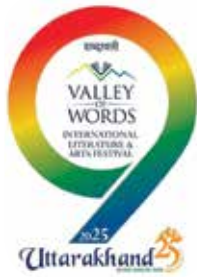
abatement, mitigation and adaptation. This can only happen in a multilateral negotiation setting such as the UNFCCC, where such decisions have to be taken by all countries collectively. On the other hand, climate economics must also learn from the projections offered by climate science models, which are based on fundamental laws of science: and take into account the outlier events or 'fat tails' and factor them into their calculations. Indeed, such 'fat tails' events only seem to be rising in frequency across the world in the form of extreme weather events: be they furious floods in the Himalayas in India or the devastating forest fires in California or the rising frequency of high velocity winds and storms. Giving heed to these can only lead to greater attention to adaptation measures in developing countries and benefit them.

CONCLUSION

While the science of climate change has progressed well, its integration with socio-economic scenarios is a work in progress. Even so, there are enough pointers to the need for urgent action in mitigation and adaptation to climate change. As climate models become more sophisticated, more specific inputs for policy action may be forthcoming. At the end of the day, both climate science and climate economics have to get into a dialogue for designing policies that can best guide abatement and adaptation measures.



A Diary of Defiance



Anju Rana's My Tryst with Cancer: A Diary transforms sixteen difficult months of diagnosis, treatment and recovery into an intimate, hopeful and deeply human narrative

AUTHOR



SANJEEV CHOPRA

15 years ago, I read and reviewed *The Emperor of All Maladies: A Biography of Cancer* by Siddhartha Mukherjee, which had just won the Pulitzer Prize for non-fiction in 2011. Mukherjee described this Emperor as a 'formless, timeless, and pervasive' adversary which could strike at will, debilitating not just the person it attacked but also the entire ecosystem around her. Over time, researchers had made slow but sure and steady progress. The Emperor was known for its non-discriminatory nature – it afflicted one and all irrespective of age, gender, status, nationality and region. Mukherjee did an admirable job weaving a potentially chaotic and depressing story into something coherent and even hopeful. Despite the many tragic deaths which littered the pages of the book, the final impression was of how much could be accomplished when a researcher's diligence, a doctor's pledge to save life, and a patient's will to live worked together.

For me, the key takeaway was the patient's will. And what better way to describe this than the review of *My Tryst with Cancer: A Diary* by Anju Rana, my vivacious neighbour at USHA Dehradun. She is our innovative emcee at tombola meets, giving a new tongue twister to each of the 99 numerals, besides coming up with ever-innovative ways of creating new prizes (along with the conventional 'full house' and four corners). When she was diagnosed with the Emperor of All Maladies, she not only decided to put up a fight but also to document it and later publish her memoirs for others to read — she endured the malady, and recorded a full recovery.

The book covers 16 crucial months. From early symptoms of severe backache, abdominal rashes and a UTI in November of 2023 to hardness in the upper area of the breast in February 2024, the diagnosis and the treatment for breast cancer from March 2024 to the final conquest in May 2025. The narrative is spread out in the form of the journal entries on different dates which she wrote in a blue diary gifted by her elder son for a 'cathartic experience' and 'to help divert the mind from the ill -effects of medicine'. Making these entries may have been difficult at times, but in retrospect, they serve as reminders that 'tough times don't last, tough people do'. This then is the story of her eight rounds of chemotherapy, one major surgery followed by 9 cycles of immunotherapy, twenty sessions of radiation and eight cycles of oral tablets for chemo. Let me highlight some key points from the milestone entries in this Diary.

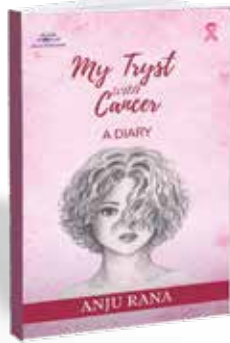
The first entry, dated 20th March, is from her parental home in Ghaziabad as she copes with the aftereffects of hair loss – she writes that this made her feel like Peris Khambatta! On 30th March, she called the barber to shave off her hair, in the process reminded of her father who too had lost his hair early on in life. On 31st March she notes her

gratitude for all the communication devices that keep her connected to the world at large in this difficult phase in which one can feel so alone. On 2nd April, she paid her tribute to researchers like Mukherjee, because of whom the malady is now curable.

Interspersed with her personal predilections come words of eternal wisdom like that of time being the best healer, and the importance of not holding any grudges. But there are moments of weakness: the thought of her Fauji son going to the Kashmir Valley on duty gives her sleepless nights. On 5th April, she recorded her therapeutic gossip sessions with her sister-in-law Priti,

who had earlier insisted that she ought to take the symptoms more seriously. The entry on 10th April is interesting: it is a clear role reversal when the son offers parental advice on how much our protagonist should exert towards household chores. Two days later, she feels like Lady Diana 'giving an audience to those who wish to call on her'.

We learn of her chemo cycles, and the process of coping with them. Even though each cycle leads to weight loss, she keeps her spirits high and on 12th May, she describes herself as 'quite a cheerful cancer patient'. As she knows what to



expect, she prepares herself for the aftereffects by engaging in reading, writing and OTT movies. The fifth cycle is scheduled in the month of May — when the mercury in the NCR is soaring — and there is a natural sense of relief when she returns to her home in Dehradun on 12th June. On the 14th of June she wonders about the laws of karma and whether this illness was a recompense for sins from the previous births. Monsoon arrives in July, but her entry on the first of this month is not about the joys of Sawan; it is about humidity, insects, snakes and slush! Her keen connect with her house-plants is clear from multiple entries, especially on 7th July. 20 days later, the mood of detachment sets in, but by the first day of August, she has a feeling 'Yes, I can do it'. She has been through five months of this battle, and realises that 'the human body has immense capacity to tolerate and also to heal on its own'.

Entries on the 24th /26th/ and 31st August give a pen picture of the surgery on the 28th, her coping mechanisms, and the great sense of relief on her return to her sister's house after surgery with family members surrounding her. She had a 'normal lunch on the dining table', but this was on account of the pain killers and the adrenaline rush. By 3rd September she records the nightmare of severe after effects in the following week. Meerut is where her grandchildren waited excitedly for Amma to come back home. As she records in her entry on 21st

September, this gave a big boost to her healing process. Ipso facto for her video interactions with the grandkids in Singapore. USHA figures twice in her account when she is on the road to recovery: first on 26th October to mark Diwali celebrations when she wears a 'nice yellow suit, and a wig' and then on 10th November when the ladies Club welcomed her as the Tambola Queen back in their midst. On 6th December her eldest teenaged grandson had his first ball dance with Amma, and she enjoyed a family wedding. Back in Meerut by the 22nd February of 2025, she looked forward to the golden Jubilee Alumni meet of Sophia school, and by 24th April the medication had stopped. The last entry on 16th May 2025 confirms that she had indeed emerged victorious in the battle with cancer! The Emperor of Maladies lost to this feisty woman, who emerged through this ordeal as a 'better and more optimistic person' who has thrown out Hurry, Worry and Curry from her lexicon, and replaced them Forgive, Forget, Patience and Gratitude.

But there are some nagging questions – especially about the many difficulties which CGHS card-holders have with some of the Max Hospital establishments, and the larger issue of overcrowding in government hospitals. Many readers of this column are likely to be covered by health insurance, but what of the vast majority for whom hospitalisation is unaffordable? Thanks to the PMJAY, some basic services are now available, but even then the out-of- pocket expenses are enough to upset the precarious balance in the life of people on the margins. Anju Rana has also flagged the issue of the break-up of the joint family – recalling an ideal when all the siblings, parents, parents-in-laws, nieces and nephews and other extended family was available and willing to extend financial, logistical and emotional support to those going through illness.

In fine, this is a book of hope, of courage, of fortitude, of friends and family, and most importantly, the need to stay positive — for the circumstances which surround us are never in our control, and it is our attitude to them which defines who we are and how we face them.

THIS DEEPLY PERSONAL ACCOUNT OF A CANCER BATTLE SHOWS HOW HUMOUR, *discipline*, AFFECTION AND INNER RESOLVE CAN COEXIST EVEN IN THE HARDEST MONTHS



Beyond Dynasties, Beyond Old Politics

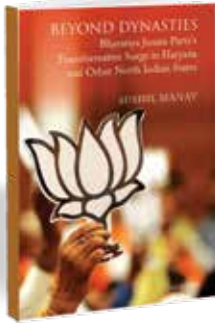
Sushil Manav's Beyond Dynasties examines how the BJP reshaped Haryana's politics, challenging decades of caste-driven dynastic dominance

SWATI MAHAJAN

For 42 years, no government in Haryana won back-to-back elections on its own. Not Congress, not INLD, not any of the coalitions that held office by threading together defectors and desperate alliances. Then a party led in the state by a man with no land, no Jat surname, and no family political legacy did it twice. If you want to understand how that happened, and what it means for Indian politics, Sushil Manav's "Beyond Dynasties: BJP's Transformative Surge in Haryana and Other North Indian States" is the only book that comes close to explaining it.

There is something almost audacious about a working journalist writing a book about the very party he has spent decades covering, and making no apologies for it. Manav, who has reported Haryana politics for several leading national dailies, has done precisely that. The result is a book that reads less like an academic treatise and more like a long, honest conversation with someone who has sat through countless press conferences in Chandigarh, chased MLAs down corridors in the Haryana Vidhan Sabha, and knows the names of the sarpanches in Sirsa the way most Delhi commentators know little beyond Lutyens.

The central argument Manav makes is not subtle. The BJP's rise across Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Delhi, and Uttarakhand represents a historic rupture from dynastic politics, the Chautalas, the Hoodas, the Badal clan, the Mulayams. From 1972 until 2014, no single party in Haryana won a consecutive absolute majority. The BJP did it twice, in 2014 and again in 2024. In 2019, the party fell



short of majority with 40 seats in 90 member assembly, and managed to run government for 5 years by cobbling together government with Dushyant Chautala's JJP that won 10 seats. For Manav, this is not mere electoral arithmetic. It is a civilisational reset of sorts, a dismantling of the feudal political architecture.

He builds his argument by tracing Haryana's political history from its formation in 1966 through decades of unstable governments, defections, and shifting coalitions until Narendra Modi's rise reshaped the landscape. Episodes such as

Bhajan Lal toppling Devi Lal's government in 1979 and Bhupinder Singh Hooda's sweeping 67-seat victory in 2005 serve as useful reminders of the state's turbulent political past.

The portrait of Manohar Lal Khattar forms the book's central focus. Manav portrays him as an outsider in Haryana politics—without a dynastic legacy, dominant caste backing, or large landholdings. In a state long dominated by Jat leadership, the rise of a Punjabi Khatri as chief minister was itself a political disruption. Importantly, Manav does not portray Khattar uncritically; he examines episodes such as the 2016 Jat reservation agitation, the farmers' protests of 2020–21, and Khattar's quiet exit in 2024, acknowledging the political costs of governance.

Where Manav is on particularly solid ground is in writing about the BJP's social engineering, the deliberate effort to build a non-

Jat majority coalition by bringing OBCs, Dalits, and non-dominant castes into a new political alliance. That ground-level texture is this book's finest quality.

The book's weaknesses emerge in its more expansive chapters on UP, Punjab, and Uttarakhand. Manav is candid in the preface that his Punjab coverage spanned only two years and his primary immersion has been Haryana. It shows. The UP and Uttarakhand chapters read more like competent journalism than first-hand testimony. The Punjab chapter, while acknowledging the BJP's limitations in a Sikh-majority state where the farmers' protests created a near-permanent wall of hostility, does not quite carry the depth of analysis the Haryana chapters do.

There are also questions the book raises without fully answering. The BJP's consolidation of power in north India has been built on a particular kind of majoritarianism, the consolidation of non-Yadav OBCs and upper castes in UP, the sidelining of Jats in Haryana, the Hindutva mobilisation in Uttarakhand. Manav acknowledges that Dalit and Muslim communities have felt the costs of this new political order, and that Adityanath's UP has had its share of controversies.

North India's political story after 2014 has generated enormous commentary and almost no sustained reportage from those who were actually there. Manav was there. That counts for a great deal.

A JOURNALIST'S INSIDER ACCOUNT OF HOW THE BJP BROKE ENTRENCHED *political* DYNASTIES IN HARYANA AND ALTERED THE BALANCE OF POWER IN NORTH INDIA

Resilience as Growth, Not Recovery

Blending philosophy, metaphor and experience, Neena Verma's book proposes a deeper understanding of resilience through adversity rather than simple endurance

In *RISE: The Deep Resilience Way*, Neena Verma offers an ambitious and philosophically rich rethinking of resilience. Rather than presenting it as mere recovery from adversity or psychological toughness, she describes resilience as a transformative human capacity—an inner strength that deepens through hardship. Verma moves beyond the popular "bounce back" narrative to what she calls "deep resilience", a process through which adversity generates new meaning, perspective, and identity rather than simply restoring equilibrium.

The book is not a conventional self-help guide promising quick solutions. Instead, it is reflective and conceptually layered, blending philosophy, metaphor, memoir, and practical exercises. Verma's central argument is that resilience involves expansion rather than survival alone. She distinguishes between restorative resilience, which helps individuals return to baseline functioning, and generative resilience, which enables people to emerge wiser and more emotionally expansive after difficult experiences. In an era that often celebrates stoic endurance, her emphasis on imagination, ethical awareness, and compassion feels refreshing.

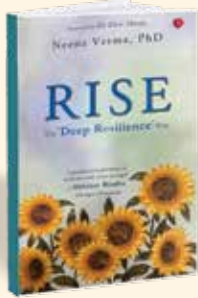
Verma uses evocative metaphors to convey these ideas. The notion of "bioluminescence"—an inner light glowing brightest in darkness—captures the paradox of growth through suffering with striking clarity. Similarly, her use of the Zen-inspired image of the "golden wind" suggests adversity as a purifying force that strips away superficial identities. At

times, however, these metaphors become so prominent that the prose drifts into abstraction, and readers seeking empirical or research-based discussions of resilience may find the book more philosophical than scientific.

The conceptual backbone of the work is the RISE model, which unfolds across four stages: Restorative Adaptation, Imaginal Growth, Supple Strength, and Expansive Emergence. Each phase is intended to guide readers from recovery toward transformation. Particularly intriguing is Verma's emphasis on imagination as a resilience resource and her argument that vulnerability and flexibility represent mature forms of strength. While the framework is accessible and coherent, the phases may feel somewhat linear for a process that is often cyclical and unpredictable in real life.

The book extends its framework through additional concepts such as the PRISM mindset and the MARQUE reflections drawn from Verma's own experiences, including a formative struggle with dengue in her teenage years. These autobiographical moments add emotional credibility and highlight one of the book's most resonant themes: embracing vulnerability as a source of dignity and growth. The REAP exercises at the end of each chapter further ground the text, encouraging readers to translate insight into practice.

Verma's central insight—that resilience is not about returning to who we were, but becoming more than we were—remains both humane and compelling in an uncertain world.



AUTHOR



VINOD KUMAR

The road from Mumbai to Latvia may require patience, but the country's calm landscapes through cobbled streets, medieval towns, and pine forests reward every mile travelled

A Quiet Baltic Journey



LATVIA



NEARLY HALF OF LATVIA'S LAND AREA IS COVERED BY FORESTS, MAKING IT ONE OF EUROPE'S GREENEST COUNTRIES

hearty and deeply connected to the land and sea. I tasted dense slices of dark rye bread, smoked fish from the Baltic coast and simple potato dishes that seemed perfectly suited to the cool climate. In a cosy restaurant with wooden interiors that reminded me of a mountain lodge, a waiter proudly explained that the soup I had ordered followed a recipe passed down through generations. Meals here feel less like hurried consumption and more like small rituals.

What stayed with me most, however, was Latvia's quietness. It is not a country that overwhelms visitors with spectacle. Instead, it invites you to slow down — to walk a little longer, to sit quietly in a square, to watch the light shift across old buildings. There is a calm rhythm here that gradually seeps into the traveller.

On my final morning, I woke early and returned to the Old Town before the streets filled with tourists. The cobblestones were still damp from a light drizzle during the night. A few shopkeepers were opening their doors, and church bells echoed softly through the empty lanes. I stopped again at the same bakery where my journey had begun. The elderly woman recognised me instantly and said with a smile, "Back again?"

I nodded, ordered the same pastry and sat by the window watching the city wake up. Travel often promises dramatic experiences, but sometimes its most lasting memories are quiet ones — a friendly conversation, a peaceful landscape, a familiar smile in a distant land. Latvia, reached through a long journey from Mumbai and a change of planes along the way, offered exactly those moments.

THERE ARE NO DIRECT FLIGHTS FROM MUMBAI TO RIGA. *Most travellers* REACH LATVIA VIA EUROPEAN HUBS SUCH AS ISTANBUL, DOHA, FRANKFURT OR HELSINKI

Reaching Latvia from Mumbai is not the sort of journey that happens in a single leap. There are no direct flights between the two cities, and the trip requires a little patience and a willingness to embrace the long route north. My own journey took me first from Mumbai to Istanbul and then onward to Riga, Latvia's capital. Somewhere between the humid bustle of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport and the calm Baltic skies above Riga, it felt as though I had crossed not just continents but moods. When the plane finally descended over patches of forest and winding rivers, the first thing that struck me about Latvia was the light — soft, pale and almost dreamy. It was close to nine in the evening, yet the sun still lingered on the horizon, casting a gentle glow over the land.

Stepping out of Riga International Airport, the air felt crisp in a way that immediately reminded me I was far from home. A cool breeze carried the faint scent of pine and the Baltic Sea. Compared to the restless rhythm of Mumbai, everything here felt



unhurried. Even the taxi ride into the city seemed quiet. As we drove along broad roads lined with trees, the driver pointed toward the Daugava River and told me, in broken English, that summer days in Latvia stretch long into the evening. "You will not sleep early here," he laughed.

Riga has the curious ability to feel both grand and intimate at the same time. On my first morning, I wandered through

the cobbled streets of the Old Town, where church spires rise above pastel-coloured buildings and narrow lanes seem to twist without warning. The city's history is written in its architecture. Gothic churches stand beside medieval warehouses, and small cafés spill onto quiet squares. Near Dome Square, I stopped at a modest bakery for coffee and a warm pastry whose Latvian name I struggled to pronounce. The elderly woman behind the counter smiled patiently at my attempt and corrected me gently. That small exchange — her laughter and my embarrassment — felt like the real beginning of my Latvian journey.

One cannot walk through Riga without noticing its remarkable Art Nouveau architecture. Entire streets are

lined with buildings decorated with elaborate sculptures, ornate balconies and swirling patterns that seem almost theatrical. Alberta Street, in particular, is a showcase of this style. I spent nearly an hour simply wandering there, pausing every few steps to look up. At one point, a young Latvian student noticed me photographing the same building repeatedly. "You are not the first," he joked. "Even we locals still look up."

Yet Latvia's charm extends far beyond its capital. A short train journey took me to Sigulda, a small town nestled within Gauja National Park, often described as the "Switzerland of Latvia." The landscape opened into forests, rolling hills and quiet rivers that seemed untouched by hurry. I rented a bicycle near the station and followed a winding trail

through the countryside. The air smelled of damp earth and pine needles, and the only sounds were the occasional rustle of leaves and distant birds. From the ruins of an old medieval castle overlooking the valley, the view stretched across miles of green wilderness.

Travel often becomes memorable because of chance encounters. In a small café in Sigulda, I ended up sharing a table with a middle-aged schoolteacher named Andris. When he discovered I was from India, his curiosity immediately surfaced. He asked about cricket, Bollywood and whether Indian summers were really as hot as people say. In return, he told me about Latvia's winters, when daylight shrinks to just a few hours and the entire countryside disappears under snow. "That is why summer feels like a

festival," he said, smiling toward the green valley outside the window.

Back in Riga, the evenings quickly became my favourite part of the day. The city slows gently after sunset. Street musicians appear in corners of the Old Town, couples walk across stone bridges, and the Daugava River reflects the golden glow of the skyline. One night, while strolling along the riverbank, I came across a group of teenagers playing guitar and singing softly in Latvian. I could not understand the lyrics, yet the melody carried a quiet melancholy that felt strangely familiar.

Food in Latvia brings its own discoveries. The cuisine is

The Midnight Run

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

Night drives are what reveal a car's character. It is behind this silent cruise that exists intricate engineering that keeps your machine humming and you relaxed

Night runs capture a rare moment on the highway, with the world moving fast while still staying calm. City lights fade in the rear-view mirror, traffic thins and the road stretches like a ribbon of dark glass illuminated only by the headlights. The engine settles into a steady purr. Tyres whisper on the asphalt. Somewhere in the distance, trucks rumble slowly along and the occasional car glides past like a ghost.

This is when a car reveals its true personality. In daytime traffic, every vehicle feels similar. You stop, crawl, accelerate and brake. Then repeat the cycle. At midnight on an open highway, differences begin to emerge. Some cars feel calm and reassuring, as if they were built for this moment. Others feel restless — the steering nervous, wind noise creeping into the cabin and the driver tiring with every passing kilometre.

Long-distance night driving is the ultimate test of an automobile. Not merely of the engine humming beneath the bonnet, but of the engineering effort behind the machine. Pistons rise and fall in perfect synchrony, crankshafts spin tirelessly and mechanical components work together in quiet harmony.

HIGH-SPEED CALM

What makes a car feel relaxed at highway speeds? Much of the answer lies in something most drivers rarely think about. Aerodynamics. Once a vehicle crosses 80 or 100 km per hour, the invisible wall of air pushing against it becomes a powerful force. Engineers spend thousands of hours shaping a car's body



to manage this resistance. Modern vehicles are sculpted to guide airflow smoothly over the bonnet, along the sides and across the roof.

Even details such as the curvature of the windscreen, the angle of the rear window and the shape of door mirrors influence how air moves around the body. Done well, the car slices through the air cleanly, reducing drag and improving stability. Poorly managed, air creates turbulence that can make a car feel unsettled at speed. That is why some vehicles glide effortlessly at 120 km per hour while others begin to feel vague or floaty. Automakers test extensively in wind tunnels and on high-speed tracks long before a car reaches showrooms. At expressway speeds, air itself becomes a serious engineering challenge.

SECRET OF STABILITY

Aerodynamics alone, however, does not create that reassuring sense of composure. Another critical factor is the chassis, the hidden framework that decides how a car

behaves on the road. Suspension geometry, weight distribution and steering calibration all play a role. Engineers aim to strike a delicate balance. A car must feel stable enough to inspire confidence while remaining responsive to steering inputs. This balance becomes particularly important on long highway drives.

A vehicle with extremely light steering may feel easy in city traffic but nervous at speed. Conversely, a slightly heavier, well-weighted steering makes a car feel planted and secure on fast highways. Automotive engineers refer to this characteristic as high-speed stability, the ability of a car to remain composed even when encountering crosswinds, uneven surfaces or sudden lane changes.

Modern vehicles also rely on electronic assistance systems to maintain control. Stability control, now standard in most cars, monitors

wheel speed, steering input and vehicle direction. If the car begins to lose grip or drift off course, the system intervenes by subtly adjusting braking or engine power. Most of the time, the corrections remain invisible. To the driver, the car simply continues down the road, calm and composed.

THE QUIET CABIN

The most underrated ingredient of a satisfying midnight highway drive is silence. Noise may seem trivial on short journeys, but over hundreds of kilometres, it becomes a source of fatigue. Engineers devote enormous effort to reducing what they call NVH — Noise, Vibration and Harshness. The battle against unwanted sound is fought on several fronts. Tyres are designed with treads that minimise road noise. Insulation materials line the floor, doors and roof. Even the thickness of window glass helps block wind noise.

In premium vehicles, the effort goes further. Laminated glass, thicker seals and acoustic dampening materials absorb vibrations before they reach the cabin. The result is a quieter interior where the outside world fades into the background. Conversations become easier, music sounds clearer and, most important, the driver can relax and yet stay alert.

On a long night drive, silence is not a luxury. It is a form of comfort.

INDIAN POTHOLE TEST

Indian highway driving adds another dimension to the challenge. Unlike the perfectly smooth surfaces used in many international tests, Indian roads can change character abruptly. One

moment the asphalt is smooth; the next it may be patched, uneven or interrupted by expansion joints. A car built for long-distance travel must absorb these imperfections without unsettling the driver.

Suspension systems are carefully tuned to balance firmness with comfort; stable enough for high speeds, yet forgiving enough for imperfect roads. Seat design becomes important too. The real test of a car seat is not how it feels during a short test drive, but how it supports the body after four or five hours behind the wheel. Automakers invest heavily in ergonomics such as lumbar support, cushioning density and seat contours to reduce fatigue.

In a well-designed car, the driver steps out after hundreds of kilometres feeling surprisingly fresh. In a poorly designed one, even a short trip can feel exhausting.

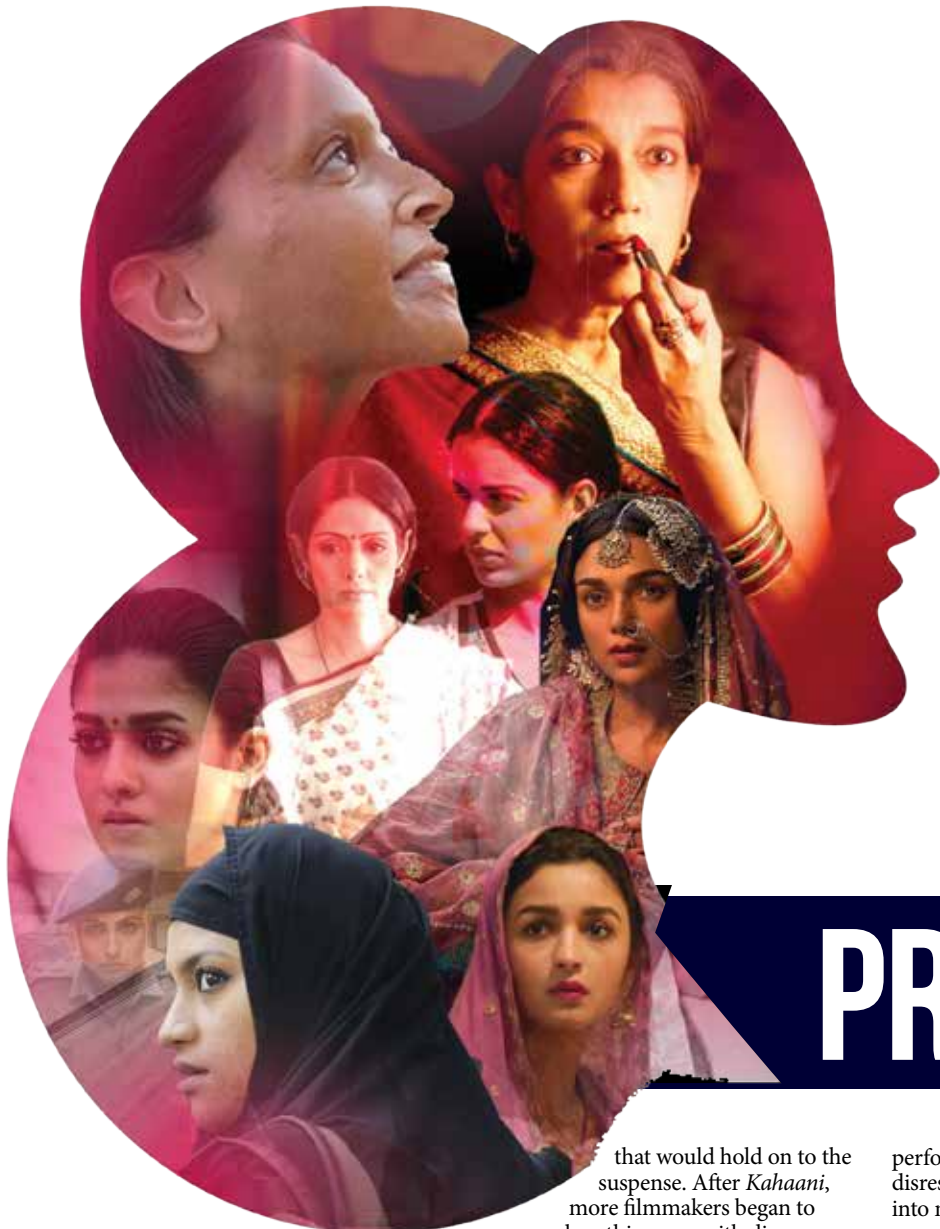
TIMES ARE A-CHANGING

India's highways are evolving. Expanding expressways and better infrastructure are encouraging more long-distance driving than ever before. Night journeys that once seemed daunting are increasingly routine. This shift is reshaping expectations from cars. Buyers still care about horsepower and mileage, but stability, comfort and refinement over long distances are becoming equally important. Drivers want vehicles that feel effortless on the highway.

For automakers, this presents both a challenge and an opportunity. Cars that succeed are not necessarily be the most powerful or feature-packed. They are ones engineered to make long journeys feel calm, stable and predictable.

Because somewhere on a dark highway, long after the traffic fades and the road opens ahead, every car faces the same test. Beneath the glow of headlights and the endless stretch of asphalt, the true character of a machine reveals itself. Is it a fairy or a beast? On India's highways, a beast is better.

IN THE GLOW OF HEADLIGHTS ON THE LONG HIGHWAY, THE TRUE character OF A CAR REVEALS ITSELF. IS IT A FAIRY OR A BEAST? ON INDIA'S HIGHWAYS, A BEAST IS BETTER



The evolving portrayal of women in Indian cinema reflects changing social realities, and audiences are increasingly receptive to nuanced female characters

RISE OF THE FEMALE PROTAGONIST

SURBHI GARG

Not until very long, stories led by women were treated as deviations from the mainstream - men would be cast as proactive, capable and physically strong. In contrast, women are sidelined or portrayed in supporting roles. However, this view has been changing gradually. Today, several powerful Indian films feature female characters at the centre of conflict, ambition and ethical choices. The change is subtle; it can be seen through casting decisions, genres associated with women and the level of commitment filmmakers demonstrate in narrating stories about women.

Kahaani (2012), directed by Sujoy Ghosh, is one of the most obvious turning points. Vidya Balan is an example of how a mainstream thriller can exist without diminishing the tension or the film's scale. The film's success changed industry perceptions regarding what type of central figure would be acceptable in this genre, historically dominated by men and gave its leading lady an intelligence and emotional conviction

that would hold on to the suspense. After *Kahaani*, more filmmakers began to explore this space with diverse stories and styles. In Vikas Bahl's *Queen* (2013), the film explored a young woman finding herself after the cancellation of her wedding, thereby allowing Kangana Ranaut's character to grow on her own without needing romantic approval. Alankrita Shrivastava's *Lipstick Under My Burkha* (2016) foregrounded female desire and autonomy, while Gauri Shinde's *English Vinglish* (2012) gave Sridevi a deeply relatable arc of self-worth. In Meghna Gulzar's *Raazi* (2018), Alia Bhatt was the main character in a political espionage film, and was more focused on the emotional impact of patriotism than on the big spectacle of it. Meghna Gulzar also directed *Chhapaak* (2020), showing the strength and dignity of an acid attack victim.

Recalibration was also adopted by large-scale productions. Sanjay Leela Bhansali built an entire epic period drama around a woman who negotiates her way through a patriarchal system with *Gangubai Kathiawadi* (2022), and its narrative scale matched her power, indicating that large-scale stories do not need a male hero. The same resemblance can also be seen across his several works, including *Padmaavat* and *Heeramandi*. Anubhav Sinha's *Thappad* (2020) also found its dramatic strength in a domestic environment, where Taapsee Pannu's very subtle

performance took a single incident of disrespect against her and magnified it into multiple areas of the importance of agency and self-worth. Regional cinema has reinforced this momentum. In Tamil, *Aaram* (2017), directed by Gopi Nainar and starring Nayanthara in the lead role as a District Collector during a public crisis, which highlighted the qualities of an administrator (competence, compassion) as driving forces behind the plot. The inclusion of these types of roles has increased the variety of women's professions, moral dilemmas, and social statuses portrayed on screen.

FEMALE PROTAGONISTS TODAY ARE INVESTIGATORS, SURVIVORS AND DECISION-MAKERS WHOSE CHOICES SHAPE THE STORY RATHER THAN EMBELLISH IT

More than just female characters taking centre-stage, it is the story that defines this phase of films featuring female leads. Protagonists are now investigators, negotiators, survivors and decision-makers all in one. Their arcs shape the film's trajectory rather than embellish it. The audience's response has affirmed that films with these types of stories should not be considered niche or novelty items, but rather essential elements of modern storytelling.

The progression of female leads through Indian cinema has been indicative of a transition in narrative focus/value. The audience has been receptive to nuanced character studies across genres, and as a result, the movie industry has shifted its output to reflect them. The result has been an array of characters whose value lies not in being a supporting cast member; rather, it is their own story that defines them. This change has made Indian Cinema more extensive and accurate in its representation of the world.



CRASH LANDING ON YOU

Bollywood Meets South Korea



When 'Crash Landing on You' premiered in late 2019, few predicted it would become one of the defining K-dramas of the streaming era

ASIF ULLAH KHAN

A South Korean billionaire heiress goes paragliding and is swept across the border by a tornado, crash-landing in North Korea - literally into the arms of a North Korean army officer. Sounds like a classic Bollywood cross-border romance, right? It does. And that's precisely why the global audience connected with it.

When 'Crash Landing on You' premiered in late 2019, few predicted it would become one of the defining K-dramas of the streaming era. Today, in 2026, it stands as a cultural landmark, a series that helped cement the global dominance of Korean storytelling alongside phenomena like 'Squid Game' and 'Parasite'.

The drama wrapped up in early 2020 with a historic 21.68 per cent average rating for its finale, peaking at 24.1 per cent, surpassing 'Guardian: The Lonely and Great God' (popularly known as 'Goblin'). At the time, it became one of the highest-rated dramas in South Korean cable television history.

More importantly, it arrived just before the COVID-19 pandemic reshaped global viewing habits. As lockdowns spread across the world, audiences discovered K-dramas in unprecedented numbers. Netflix's global distribution turned the show into a cross-continental hit, especially in Southeast Asia, the Middle East, Latin America and India - regions where Bollywood-style melodrama already had a devoted fan base.

The 'Bollywood meets Seoul' comparison felt less like a gimmick and more like cultural synergy.

The writer revealed that the premise was loosely inspired by a real-life 2008 incident in which South Korean actress Jung Yang's boat was swept toward North Korean waters near the maritime border. That near-crossing of the 38th parallel became the seed of a fictional love story that humanised an otherwise politically charged divide.

What truly set the series apart was its portrayal of ordinary North Koreans.

Earlier, South Korean films often depicted the North through a narrow lens: dictatorship, poverty, surveillance and brutality. While those realities weren't ignored, 'Crash Landing on You' offered something rare: humour, warmth, community life and relatable daily routines.

Director Lee Jeong-hyo worked closely with North Korean defectors to ensure authenticity in dialect, slang and social details. Portraits of Kim Il-sung and Kim Jong-il were shown prominently in homes and propaganda slogans lined the streets - subtle reminders of the political backdrop. Yet the focus remained on friendships, loyalty and small acts of kindness.

Some viewers praised the humane portrayal; others argued it softened the image of the North Korean military. The debate itself reflected how deeply invested audiences were.

The chemistry between Son Ye-jin and Hyun Bin fuelled global fascination. Having first worked together in 'The Negotiation', rumours swirled even before filming began.

Those rumours proved true. In a twist worthy of the script, the co-stars married in March 2022, turning fiction into reality and further cementing the drama's legacy in pop culture history.

In the story, heiress Yoon Se-ri falls for Captain Ri Jeong-hyeok, who risks everything to hide and protect her. Episode 15 left viewers heartbroken when Captain Ri, after slipping into the South to save Se-ri, is arrested despite eliminating the villain.

As the finale approached, fans flooded 'Twitter' - now 'X' - demanding a happy ending. The creators obliged. The reunion in Switzerland delivered the fairy-tale closure audiences craved.

The chemistry between Son Ye-jin and Hyun Bin fuelled global fascination. Having first worked together in 'The Negotiation', rumours swirled even before filming began

It may have felt like Bollywood - dramatic, sentimental and destiny-driven - but what truly resonated was the quiet tragedy beneath it: millions of Koreans separated by the Demilitarised Zone, families divided for decades and love constrained by geopolitics.

Six years on, 'Crash Landing on You' is more than just a hit drama. It accelerated the global rise of K-dramas on streaming platforms, strengthened cultural bridges between East Asia and South Asia and remains a gateway series for first-time viewers, while redefining how North-South narratives could be told - with empathy instead of caricature.

In hindsight, the series arrived at a pivotal moment, just before the world shut down and audiences began seeking emotionally rich, escapist storytelling. Like the best Bollywood romances, it blended music, sacrifice and longing with the enduring promise that love can transcend even the most heavily fortified borders.



WHAT'S COMING NEXT?

OUR CORRESPONDENT

From 'Age of Attraction' to 'Aspirants', here is a selection of new OTT offerings for you to enjoy

AGE OF ATTRACTION

Hosted by Nick Viall and Natalie Joy, a group of daters will discover if love is truly ageless in this 'Netflix' reality TV show, which will see singles searching for their soulmates, but with age gaps. It's a test to witness whether years will come between their love. It'll stream on March 11.



VIRGIN RIVER S7



With the previous season's jaw-dropping cliffhanger, the fans can end their wait with the return of the series with its seventh season on March 12 on 'Netflix'.

MADE IN KOREA

Starring Priyanka Arulmohan, Park Hye-jin and Jaehyun Jang in pivotal roles, this slice-of-life adventure drama follows Shenba facing betrayal, personal growth and new friendships in Seoul. It'll stream on March 12.



SANKALP



The Amazon MX Player's political thriller, directed by filmmaker Prakash Jha, stars Nana Patekar, who makes his OTT debut. To be released on March 12, the series is a saga of mentor vs mentee in the world of politics.

ASPIRANTS S3

Naveen Kasturia, Shivankit Singh Parihar, Abhilash Thapliyal, Sunny Hinduja, Namita Dubey, and Tengam Celine, with Jatin Goswami as the newest addition to the cast, are set to arrive in the third season of the popular 'Prime Video' show on March 13.

